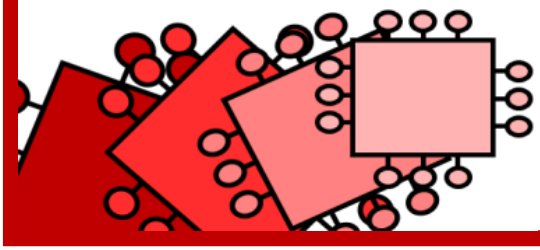
This exemplar BTEC National Information Technology Unit 3 – Learning Aim A (3.1) assignment was produced by a Year 12 student

Exemplar Assignment

The assignment was graded Distinction.

The grade was not adjusted during moderation.

This file will show you in detail how the best fit grading approach was applied and how to effectively tackle the necessary evidence required for the Distinction criteria in the assignment as well as the Pass and Merit criteria. This exemplar should only be used for informational purposes only and to give an idea of how to tackle the Learning Aim and not as something to copy from. Plagiarism of this exemplar most likely will be detected on your assignment if not credited appropriately.



How Social Media Websites Can Be Used to Promote Businesses

Introduction

In my report, I will be discussing about how social media can be used to promote small businesses and how businesses can use social media in many ways to promote their content to a wider audience. Social media these days is vital to building connections between other businesses, alongside attracting customers and followers who may be interested in what you are selling and almost all businesses that exist nowadays use a portion of social media to promote their business to a considerable extent more than without social media.

It is often also used in businesses to promote their users to visit their other websites or social media pages, alongside providing customer service to those who have enquires or complaints regarding products or services. As well as this, many different forms of social media also allow customers and followers to interact with brands that they may not know about through the use of comments and sharing which therefore allows new customers to become interested in the products they are selling.

Social media also allows businesses to communicate effectively with their customers to alert them to any changes or updates to their products and services usually through the use of posts and videos, alongside allowing businesses to post engaging content and join other groups to promote their small businesses to communities nearby them.

I will be discussing these different factors because my client, the Chamber of Commerce has asked me to create a report on using social media for business purposes to deliver to the members of the community.

The Social Media Platforms Available for Businesses

In this section, I will be discussing the different social media platforms which are available for businesses to use which in this case I will be discussing Facebook, Instagram, X, YouTube, WhatsApp and TikTok and the statistics for these different social media platforms for businesses.

The structure and features of each social media site

Facebook:

The first social media site I will be talking about is Facebook. Facebook is a social media platform that allows you to share articles, videos, photos and most other kinds of media with friends and family which makes it a personal use social media platform. It also allows users to communicate with friends they know in real life and friends that they only know digitally.

Companies can then use this platform as it is a social networking platform to make an appearance on the platform. Facebook allows users to also sign up and create their own personal profile from which they can log-in to at any time and post new content and interact with the community.

Features:

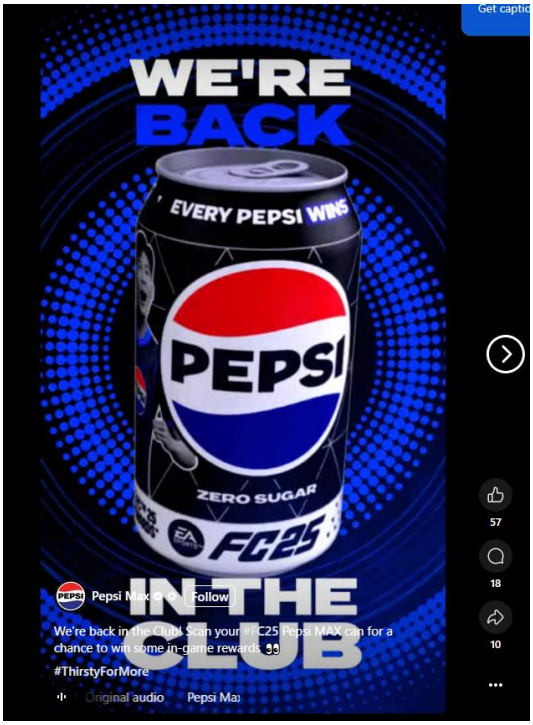
Sponsored Posts:

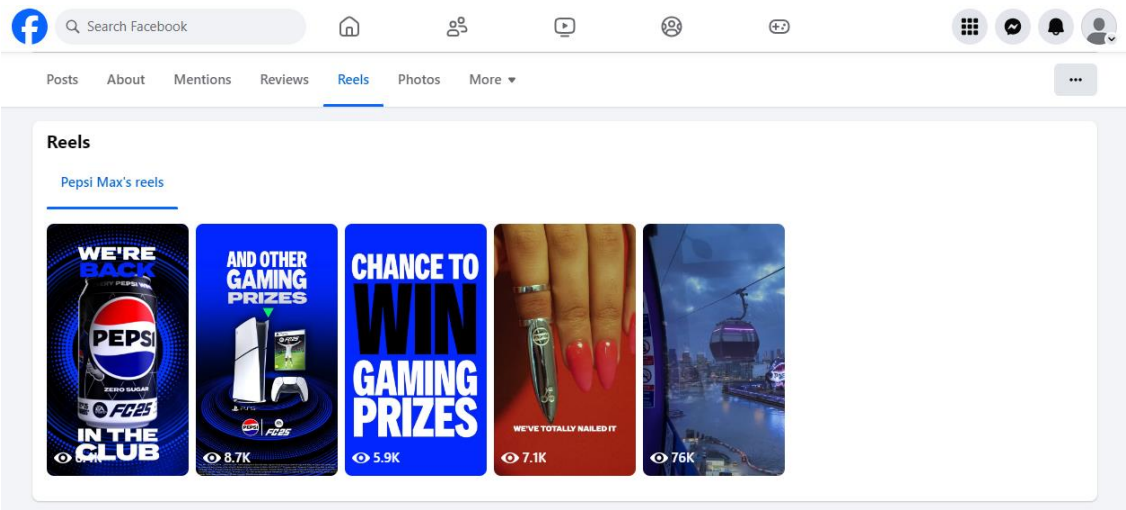
Facebook features sponsored posts which are often used by businesses on many social media platforms to interest users about products or services while they are searching through their main dashboard. The positive effect of these for businesses are that businesses can easily promote new products and services and make them visible to more people than just making a simple post, as well as being able to easily show off products that already exist which are quite popular. However, the negative effect of sponsored posts includes the facts that fraud in the form of data theft and virus infections is often committed using sponsored posts as anyone can pay to create sponsored posts and the business promoting products cannot

directly act upon this. Here is an example of a sponsored post on Facebook, by KFC, which use these posts to reach a wider audience.

Facebook Reels:

Facebook features short-form video content known as Facebook Reels which are also used by many businesses to promote their products and services in videos up to 90 seconds long. The positive effect of Facebook Reels is that businesses can easily promote content in short concise videos which tend to perform better with different audiences who may not want to watch an extremely long video or read an extremely long post and Facebook Reels can also be easily promoted via the use of Facebook Stories, which is another feature of the platform. However, the negative effects of Reels are that businesses who want to promote products or services with more descriptive content cannot do so if it is longer than 90 seconds. As well as this, Reels creates a vertical video instead a regular horizontal video which may not work well for businesses who want to promote physical products.
Here is an example of Facebook Reels which are posted by Pepsi.

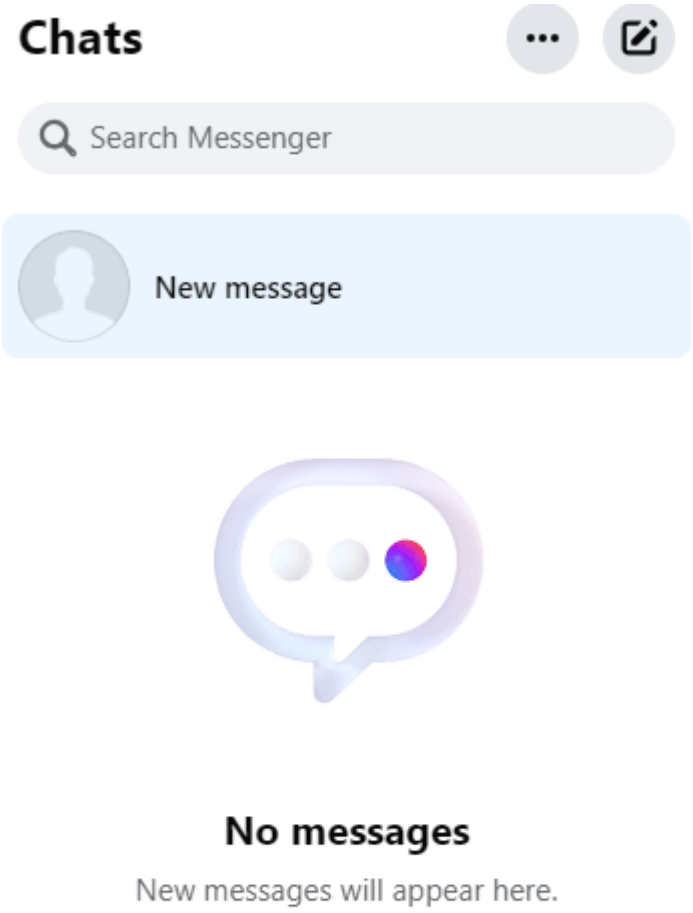




Facebook Messenger:

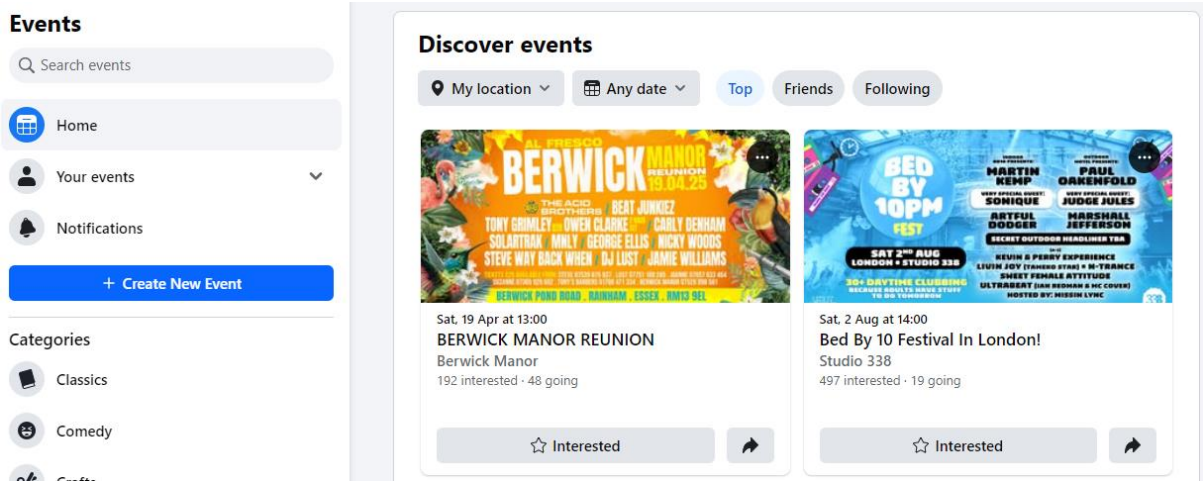
Like many other social media platforms, Facebook features a private messaging application called Facebook Messenger which allows users to directly connect to friends and from there have private conversations between one another. Businesses can use this to their advantage as this therefore allows customers to directly connect to them and enquire about their products and services. The positive effect of this is that businesses can directly contact their customers and from there offer customer service to their customers to help with their enquires and complaints alongside supporting people who bought products and service from their business. However, the negative effects of this are that not everyone wants to be receiving messages from businesses about products and many businesses operate at different times of the day and some people do not want to be disturbed at certain times of the day. Private messages are also commonly

associated with scams because no one knows who the business account is run by, and it also makes the business seem like they don't want to interact with a community. Here is what Facebook Messenger looks like:



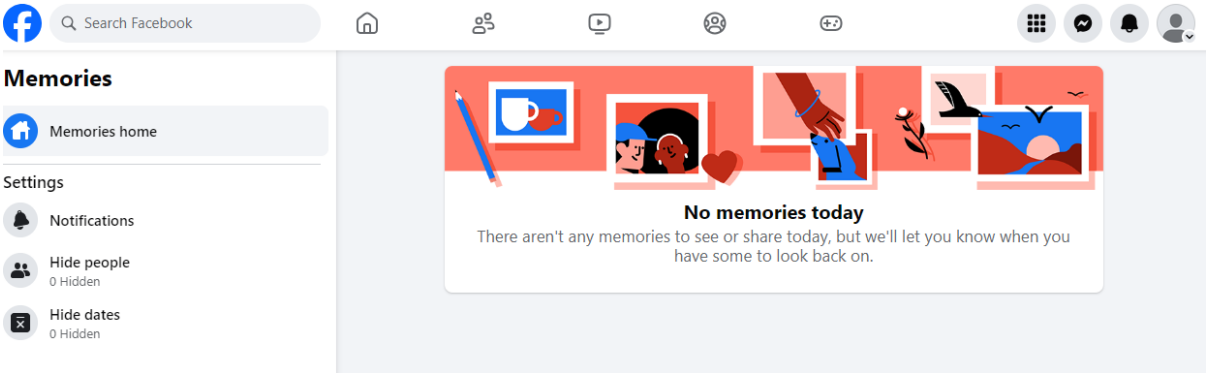
Facebook Events:

Facebook features Events so people can plan dates which may be useful for business that are advertising holidays. The positive effects of Events are that businesses can promote products based on specific dates or holidays in the period that is given to them and can also promote products when people in general may be on holiday. The negative effects of Events are that not all people want to be advertised to on certain days, some people also cannot attend events due to time zones as well and that products promoted on certain days usually do not gain as much attention as others. Here is what Facebook Events looks like:



Facebook Memories:

Facebook also features Memories which allow users to look back at the past and see their previous posts they made and how much has changed since then, which can allow businesses to promote events based on people's nostalgia. The positive effect of Memories is that businesses can get a nostalgic feel and promote products that make have been discontinued long ago, as well as creating new products inspired by these discontinued products. However, the negative effects of this would be that not all discontinued products were meant to last and that not everyone wants to bring back old products which could result in a commercial failure. Here is what Facebook Memories looks like:

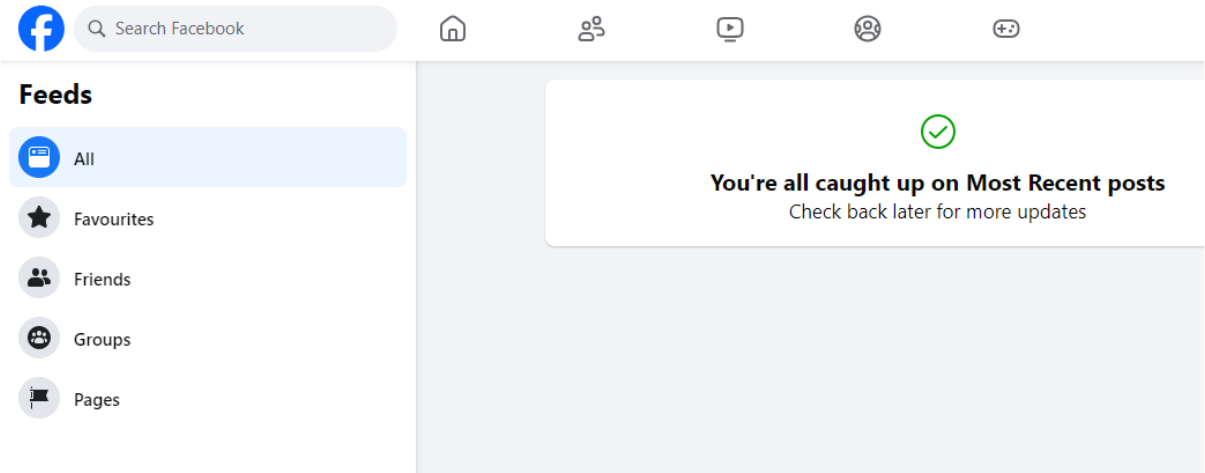


Facebook Feeds:

Facebook also features Feeds which allows users to look at recent posts of user's that they follow and the posts of their friends and groups. This can be useful for businesses as they can use to their advantage by getting people to follow them and then posting regularly so that posts will appear in people's feeds. The positive effect of Feeds is that businesses can easily create new posts and from there promote products and services to keep their followers interested in their brands by following their account. However, the negative effect of Feeds is that cyber criminals can pretend to be a

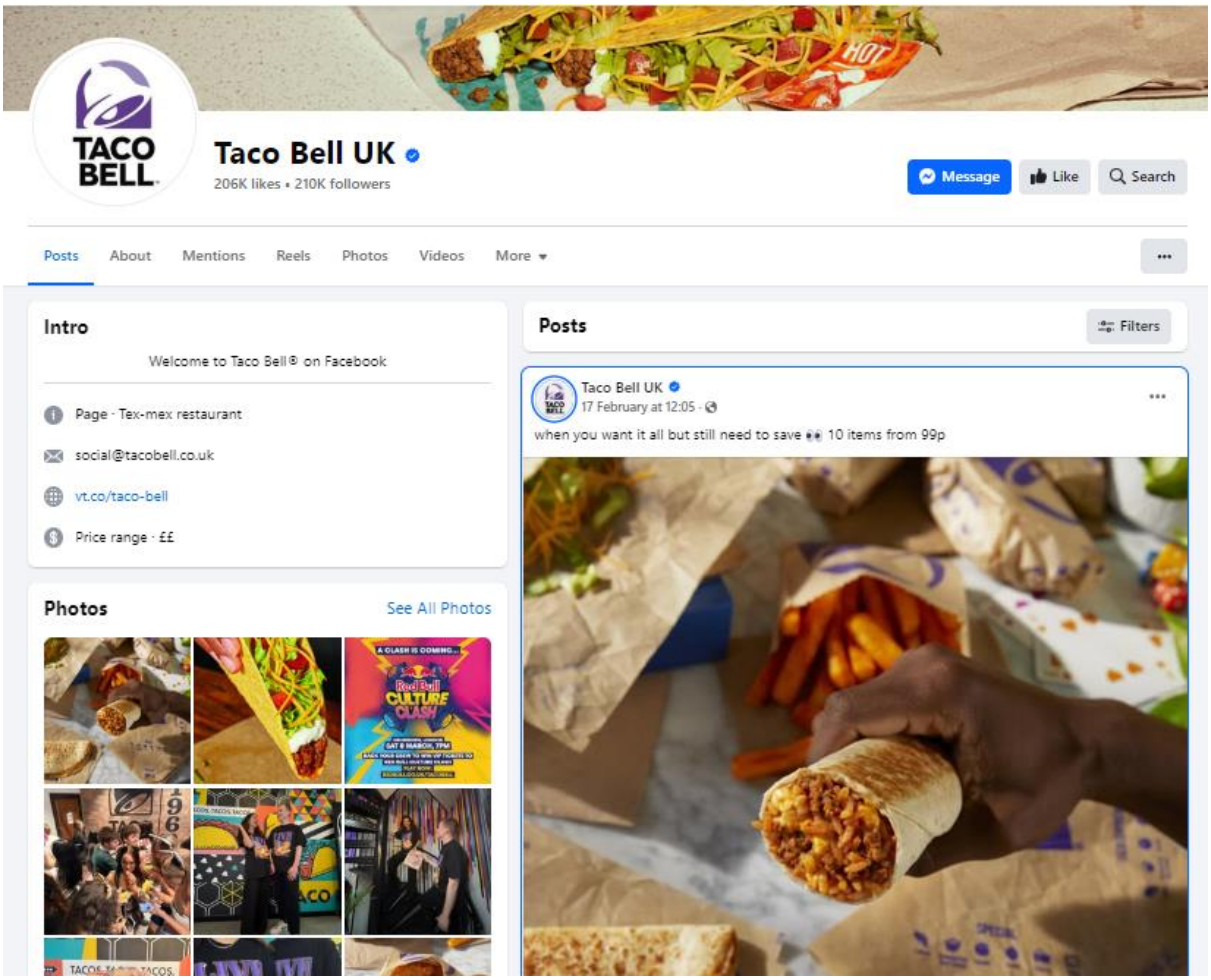
[redacted] [redacted]

business or company that people know and from there users could be promoted malicious software in links alongside scams used to collect personal information via the use of phishing and data pharming by promoting links to suspicious unprotected websites where users can enter their details. Here is what Facebook Feeds looks like:



Facebook Profiles:

Facebook allows users to sign up and create a profile on their social media website from which they can then post content such as images, videos and Facebook Reels alongside customising their About Me and setting a profile photo. This can be useful to businesses because they could feel that they are recognised on the platform and then from there can promote their content to followers, customers and other businesses to create connections. The positive effects of Facebook Profiles are that the business feels recognised on Facebook and they are able to make connections and gain followers and customers while posting content. The negative effect of Facebook Profiles however is that businesses do not know if a fake account has been set up in the name of their company pretending to be them and promoting malicious content and if they are the business cannot directly intervene as the account may be posting links to malware in their content or may be committing data theft via the use of data pharming. Here is an example of a Facebook Profile, the business being Taco Bell.



Twitter/X:

Twitter, now known as Elon Musk owned “X” is a social media platform which allows users to share videos, photos, articles, and most other kinds of media with friends and family alongside a wider community which makes it a personal use social media platform. It allows users to communicate with friends they may know in real life alongside friends that they may know only in the digital world.

Companies can then use this platform to promote their products and services as it is a social networking platform to make a presence on the platform. Twitter allows users to create their own personal account from which they can then post content and interact with the community.

Features:

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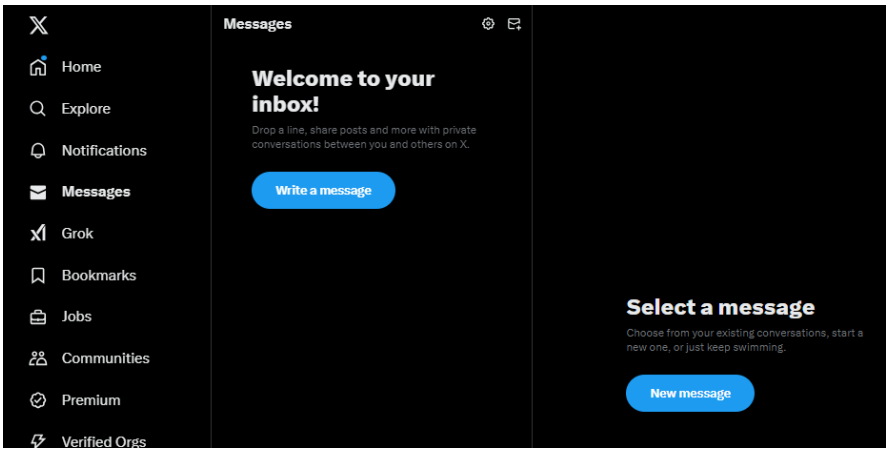
Messages

Like Facebook, Twitter features a private messaging application called Messages which allows users to directly connect with businesses and enquire about their products. The advantages of this to businesses is that businesses can directly contact customers about products and offer customer service to people who have already bought products from the company. However, the risk with private messages is that they are often associated with scams because no one knows who the actual account is run by even if they are verified, and it also makes businesses seem like they do not want to communicate with a community. Here is what Twitter Messages looks like:

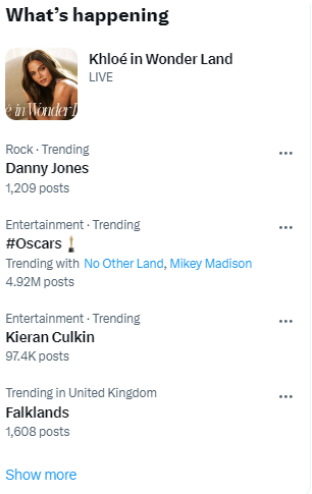


Tweets and Retweets

Twitter users have the option to post content in the form of tweets, and users can also retweet posts that they like to their friends and to their followers. Tweets can be up to 280 characters unlike Facebook, but this allows users to get straight to the point with their messages except for specific users who can write up to 4000 characters which are subscribed to Twitter Blue. This is great for businesses who want to go into details about what their product is about and describe how a product may function. The risks of this however is that Twitter Blue is a subscription service which means that businesses have to pay money in order to use Twitter Blue and small businesses may not be able to afford Twitter Blue, and customers may not want to read extremely long details about a products information which may result in less sales compared to a regular tweet. Here is an example of a tweet by the business of Microsoft.

What's Happening

Twitter also features the What's Happening headline which allows people to find out about the most recent events happening in the world. This could be part of their feed as users can follow accounts to create a personalised feed for them and from there an algorithm determines what type of content that the end user may want to see. This could be great for businesses as they can share information about new products that have been released or events going on. The risks of this are that not everyone wants to be advertised to about new products that now exist in their feed.



Who To Follow

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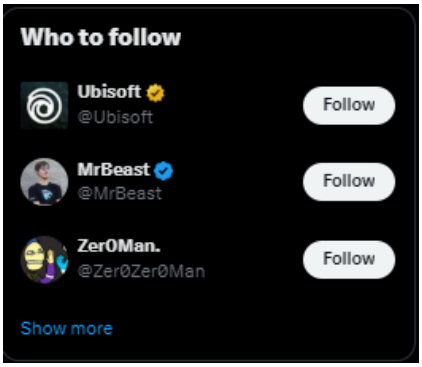
Twitter also features a who to follow tab which recommends users via the use of cookies who they might like to follow. This is great for businesses as they can use to this to their advantage by being added to the list depending on what people have been searching on Twitter. The risks with this are that not everyone wants to try out new brands, small businesses are unlikely to get as much recognition compared to big corporations and people may not want to be advertised to in their who to follow tab simply from one thing they searched up. Here is what the who to follow tab looks like:

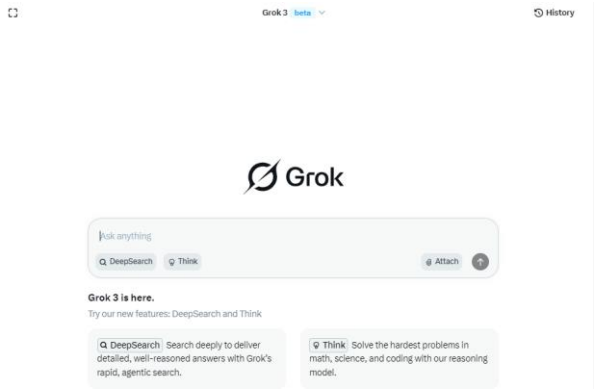


Grok

X features an artificial intelligence model called Grok which allows users to input and ask questions if they want to find out more information about a certain topic/resource or if they want to create an image/video in general and therefore would use resources from the internet to generate responses to these enquires using live data. Its key features are DeepSearch which is a next-generation search engine to scan the internet and X to deliver clear and concise answers to its end-user.

It also features Image Analysis and Generation which allows Grok to interpret uploaded images and from there generate high-quality images using models like FLUX.1 or Aurora. Grok also features Grok Analysis which allows the AI model to summarise posts, conversations, or trending discussions and from there add context for users to understand. Other features include Long Context Handling which allows Grok to process extended conversations up to 128,000 characters alongside Web Search Integration which allows Grok to incorporate results from the Internet into responses while creating its sources.

Grok also features the ability to upload a variety of files for it to analyse including PDFs, but this is only for X Blue users. Grok also allows the multitasking of conversations which therefore allows it to respond to several different conversations at once. Here is what Grok looks like:



Jobs

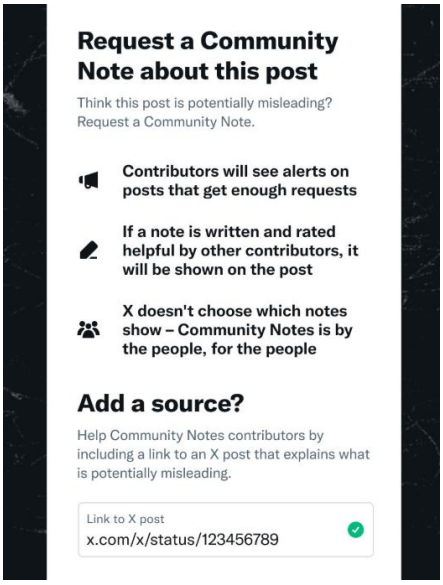
X features a job finder application called Jobs and this allows users to search for jobs and employment in their local area alongside allowing corporations to use a premium feature called X Organizations which is a premium feature like X Blue to create unlimited job posts on the platform, alongside allowing corporations to show their top roles to their audience, promote jobs using AI targeting with its performance advertising.

Jobs in a way mimics other job employment business platforms such as LinkedIn and Indeed.com. The positives of Jobs are that businesses can easily promote job opportunities and employment to different people living in the nearby area which is perfect for small businesses. The negatives of Jobs are that cyber criminals can lie about being a certain business/corporation and therefore can promote jobs that don’t exist, and businesses can only be verified by an official administrator for X which means that small businesses are unlikely to get recognition compared to big businesses and corporations.

Community Notes

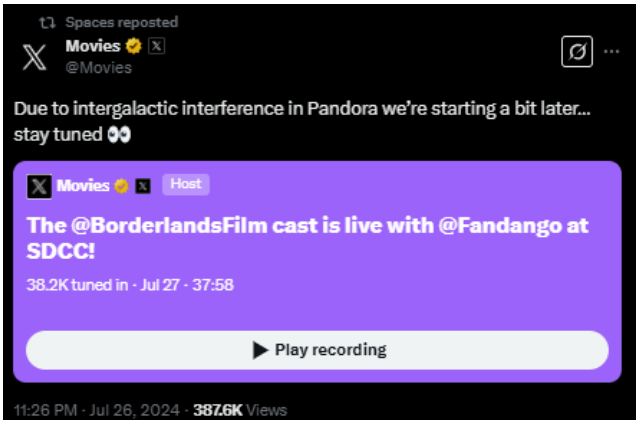
[redacted] [redacted]

X features Community Notes which is a feature that allows users to fact check posts by adding context or corrections to posts which promotes the accuracy of posts alongside reducing the likelihood of misinformation in Tweets. This could be useful in the case where that if an account pretending to be a business tried to promote content that was trying to mimic a business but spread malware, any user could add context to the posts stating that the following content was not promoted nor endorsed by the original business. The positive effects of Community Notes are that it allows users to fact check posts by reducing the likelihood of misinformation and promoting the accuracy of posts through the use of allowing any user to edit the Community Notes of a post. However, the negative effect of Community Notes is that users could in turn be cyber criminals and put in the Community Notes on the post that this business is a legitimate business and that the original business is a fake business and could trick users into clicking on suspicious links that could lead to malware alongside data pharming by collecting user information.
Here is an example of what a request for a Community Note looks like:



X Spaces

X features X Spaces which is another feature of X that allows users to enter live audio chat rooms for hosting or joining real-time live discussions and can support up to 100 different speakers in the same chat room alongside unlimited listeners at any time. Currently, only speakers can speak on iOS or Android while web users can only listen to the audio chat room. The positive effects of X Spaces are that a wider community can join in and interact with businesses if they want to use this as a way to promote products live to their target market and audience, alongside allowing the community to actually communicate directly through voice to the business and enquire about products or services alongside providing feedback. The negative effects however of X Spaces is that businesses do not know exactly who users are and so therefore users could say things that could be damaging to the reputation of the business such as negative comments or display inappropriate behaviour that the business cannot directly act upon. Here is an example of an X Space recording that has been put into a post:



Instagram:

Instagram, like Facebook, is a social media platform which allows users to post short-form content in the form of photos, videos and stories. Instagram allows users to connect with friends and family they may know in real life alongside friends that they may know in the digital world online. Instagram is owned by Meta, which is the same company that owns Facebook and both platforms are used as personal-use social media platforms. Businesses can make use of Instagram to reach out to their target audience and is a great platform for small businesses who are just starting out as they can reach a wide audience on Instagram.

Features:

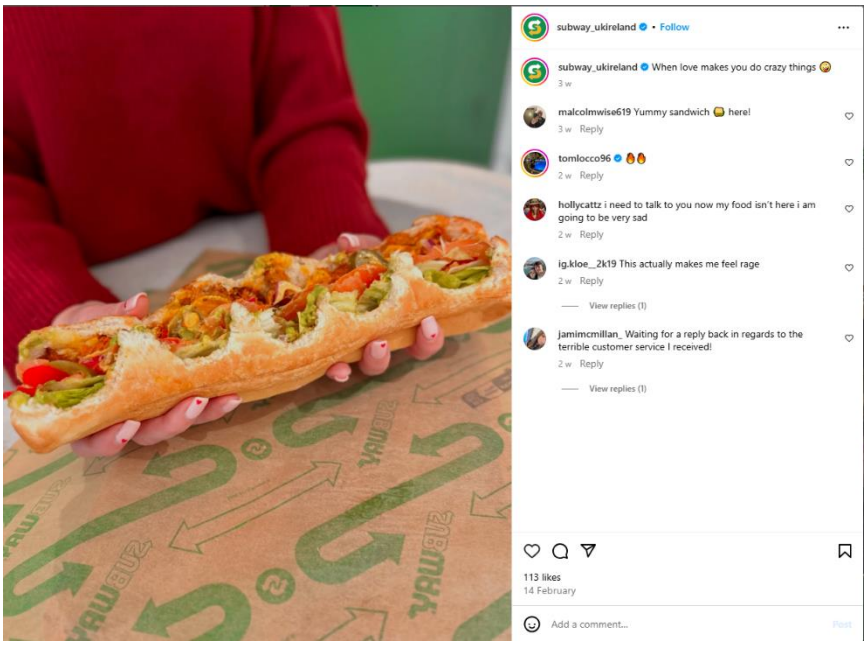
Instagram Reels

Instagram has reels which are short-form videos in which businesses are much more likely to gain more views. This is good for advertisers who wish to promote their content in short-form videos, and they are often viewed more often than long-form videos in comparison, as well as being easily promotable. The risks of Reels however are that businesses who want to promote products for longer than 3 minutes cannot do so with Reels which results in poor promotion of products, and it results in a vertical style video which may not be good for physical products. Here is an example of a reel on Instagram from Subway:

[redacted] [redacted]

Instagram Posts

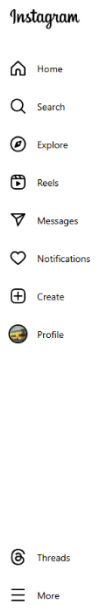
Instagram allows users to post and share photos, up to 10 carousels per video and videos up to 60 seconds in length. It allows users to post content with captions, hashtags and location information. There is also filtering and editing tools for posts to enhance visual content. The positive for businesses is that they can promote their content easily and share it to a wide range of people. The negatives however are that anyone can make posts and therefore cyber criminals could pretend to be the business and promote content that is harmful to users. Here is an example of a post on Instagram from Subway:



Instagram Dashboard

Instagram only has a simple dashboard unlike Facebook which displays only photos and videos uploaded by followers/friends. This is great for businesses who want to use a platform that is simple and easy to understand to promote their products. The risks of this for businesses however is that companies who prefer to display their main contents of their account cannot do so which can make it harder to promote more than one product at one time.

Users can also connect their Instagram accounts to other social media sites to share their posts with other platforms. Here is what the Instagram dashboard looks like:



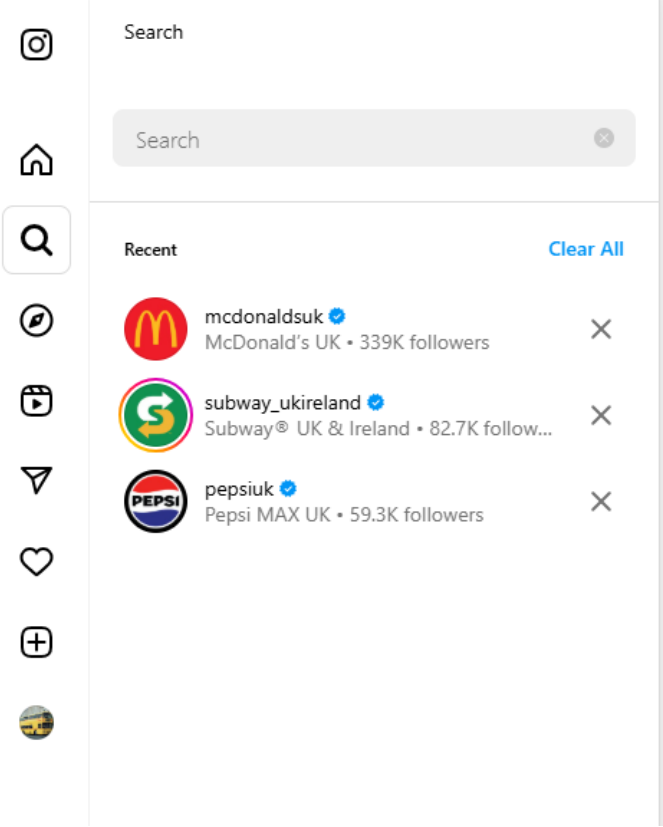
Likes/Follows/Friends

On Instagram, people can follow other users and users can check the number of likes, followers, and friends that they have. This is great for businesses who want to create a partnership with different influencers and different companies as it can show that both businesses have a good relationship. However, the risks of this are that certain influencers/businesses could break the relationship soon after which would result in the business having to unfollow the user, people falling for scams which the company can't do anything about e.g. a fake account following a real influencer which users then interact with. Here is an example of this, showing McDonald's profile:

[redacted] [redacted]

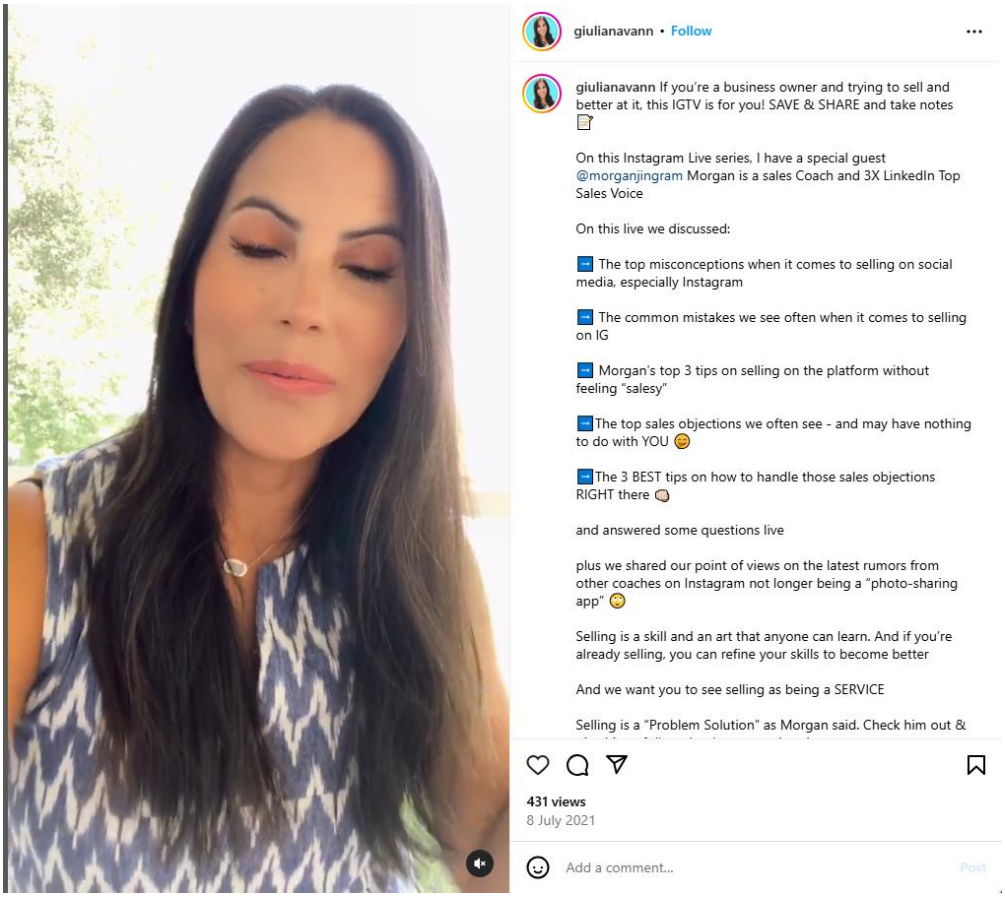
Searching for Posts/For You Page

Instagram also features the ability to search for posts and a for you page. This is great for businesses as it allows businesses to create networks in networking as well as encourage users to watch their posts. This may however be a risk for companies that prefer to use a more advanced user interface because Instagram can only display the main contents of their account. Here is what the searching for posts looks like:



IGTV

IGTV also known as Instagram TV is another feature of Instagram that allows users to share longer videos up to 10 minutes long for most users but up to 60 minutes for verified users directly in people's feeds or profiles although it has more so recently been merged into regular video features. The positive effects of this are that businesses can promote content like physical products in more detail compared to if they were to use Instagram Reels and it allows businesses to easily be able to interact with their customers more. The negative effects of this are that cyber-criminals can pretend to businesses and use Instagram TV to mass promote malware, alongside criticism in the form of negative comments which could be made by anyone as anyone can make IGTV posts. Here is an example of an IGTV post:



Multi-Platform Support

Instagram can be accessed via mobile apps using iOS and Android, desktop and web browsers. This allows people to access content through a wide range of different devices and therefore allows for a wider audience on posts using Instagram as the platform is not limited on how it can be used. However, not all the different platforms utilise the support of posts which as a result doesn't allow certain devices to post at all and instead only view posts or edit posts they have made recently. The positive effect for businesses is that their users can access their content from many different devices at one time and so can easily share content. The negative effect for businesses is that certain devices do not utilise the support of posting unlike other devices.

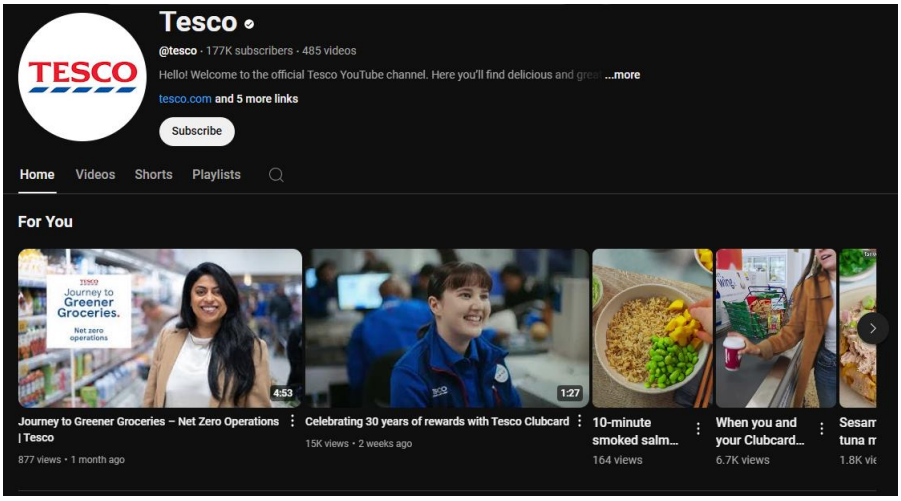
YouTube:

YouTube is a social media platform which allows users to create an account and post videos and short-form content videos known as YouTube Shorts, alongside gaining subscribers and from that earning money with the YouTube Partner Program. YouTube has been owned by Google since 2006. YouTube is great especially for businesses promoting practical products. Businesses can make use of YouTube to reach out to their target audience and YouTube is a great platform for small businesses who are just starting out as they can reach a wide audience on YouTube.

Features:

Uploading Videos

On YouTube, users can upload videos or YouTube Shorts (short-form videos) using channels which people can subscribe to. This is good for businesses who want to promote their content using videos and influencer sponsorships as it allows businesses to reach a wider audience on YouTube. However, the risks of this are that fake accounts also exist on YouTube which claim to be the real accounts of the same company and so people fall victim to scams related to this and businesses cannot use photographs on YouTube to promote content except on the community page but that requires subscribers to create. YouTube Shorts as well can only be up to 60 seconds, which is not possible for businesses who require an in-depth description of their product and not possible for businesses in which videos are longer than 60 seconds. Here is an example of a profile with videos, in this case the business is Tesco:



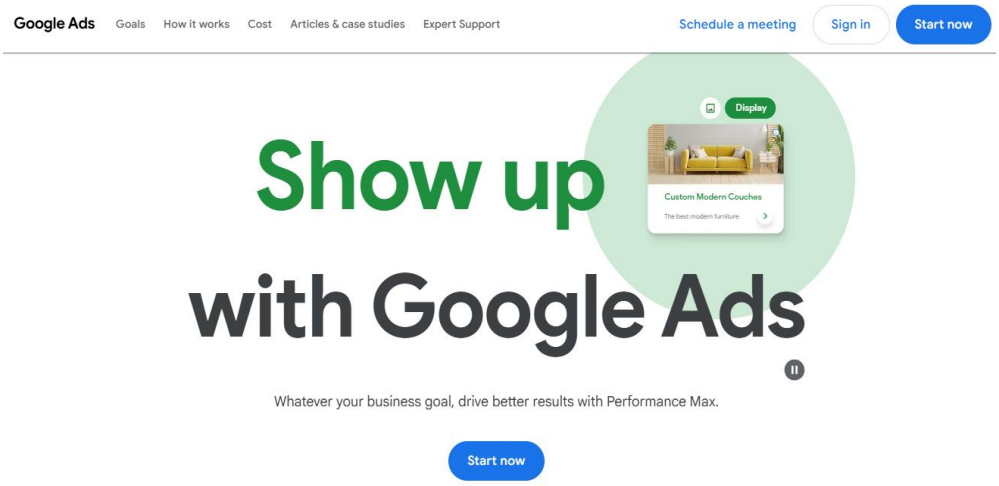
Physical/Practical Products

YouTube is perfect for businesses with physical and practical products. However, the risks with this are that YouTube has a wide range of different products that are being marketed, some of which may be the exact same product being promoted by a different company and most products promoted on YouTube tend to be prototypes of final products before they finally occur. Here is an example of a support video for a practical product, the TS5150 printer which is made by Canon:

Google Ads

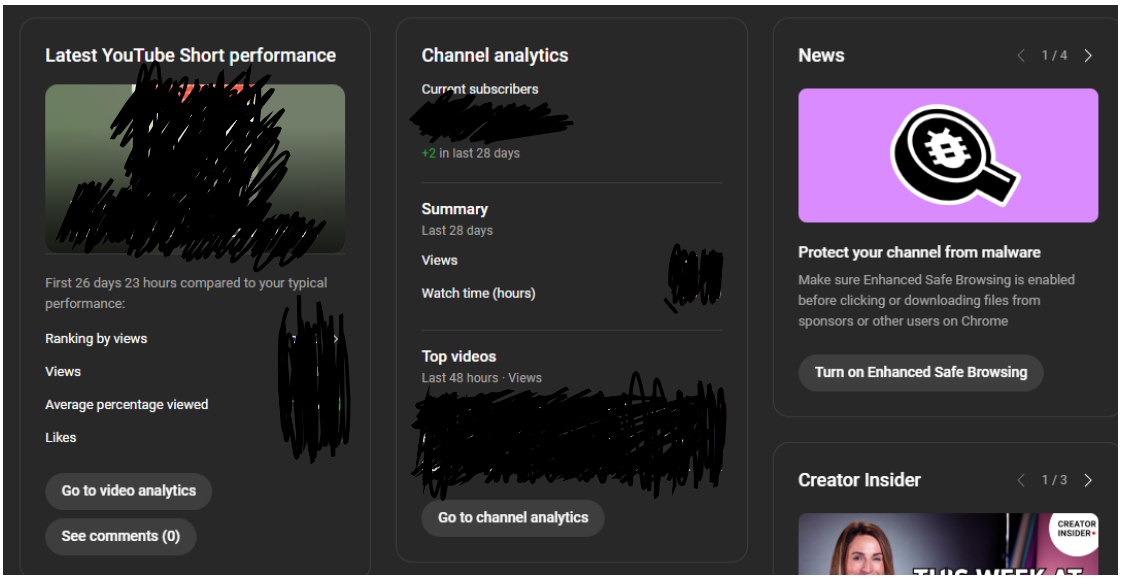
Businesses can use Google Ads through YouTube to enrol advertisements they want onto YouTube for people to watch during an ad break. This is great for businesses who want to promote their content using advertisements that are supposed to represent what television advertisements are like while earning money per watcher. However, the risks of using Google Ads are that it first of all costs money to promote products using the service and to enrol them on YouTube videos which not a lot of businesses have including small businesses, anyone can create a Google Ad even fake accounts of the real businesses which can then be used to promote scams and also not everyone wants to watch advertisements on YouTube videos hence users could use AdBlock which would result in the business not earning any money.

[redacted] [redacted]



YouTube Studio

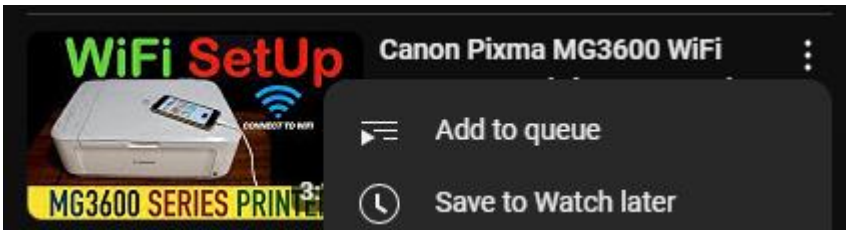
Businesses can carry out editing easily and see their most recent statistics as YouTube Studio has a built-in editor to aid businesses. The advantages of using YouTube Studio are that the built-in editor includes multiple features to meet what businesses and content creators require to make their videos. However, the risks of using YouTube Studio are that users must be trained to understand how to use YouTube Studio correctly and certain features of YouTube Studio can be difficult to understand and do unless you understand how to do them. Here is what YouTube Studio looks like:



Libraries/Watch Later

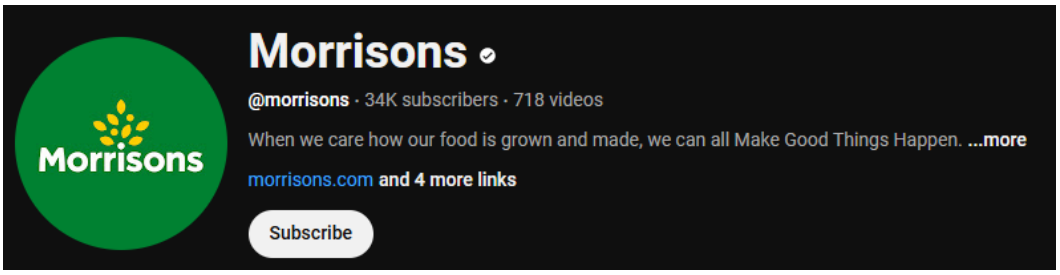
[redacted] [redacted]

YouTube also features libraries which allows users to save videos that they enjoy and watch them later, and a Watch later feature also exists on YouTube. This is useful to businesses as this allows them to determine whether users may be interested in watching their advertisements based on demographics. The risks of this are however that not all users after saving videos in the Watch later section watch the videos later either due to being busy or operating at different time zones as well as libraries being harder to search for if they have saved the video in the wrong library location accidentally. Here is how you would use the Watch later function:



Subscriptions

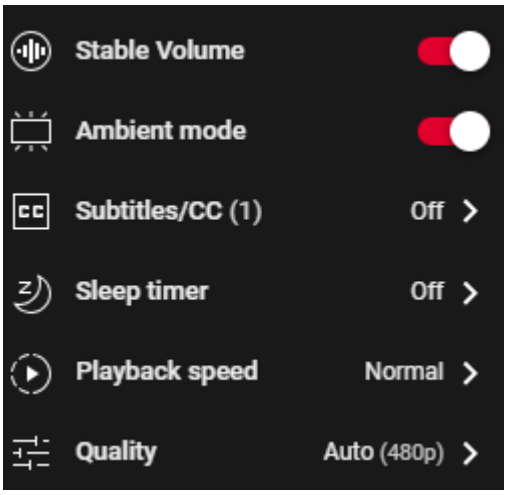
YouTube shows the list of people that people are subscribed to which allows users to check who they are subscribed to. This is useful for businesses as they can create new relations and sponsorships using this with other businesses and influencers. The risks of this however are that anyone can subscribe to accounts so fake accounts of businesses could easily subscribe to other accounts pretending to be real business and so can easily scam unsuspecting users as well as businesses having to cancel the subscription if their sponsorship or relation ends which can make it harder to find the business that was once sponsoring an influencer's videos. Here is an example of the subscriptions feature for Morrisons user page:



Video Playback

[redacted] [redacted]

YouTube features a video playback function which allows users to watch videos in resolutions of 144p to 8K, alongside allowing the playback of the video to be sped up or slowed down (can be set between x0.25 to x2). It also allows the use of captions along picture-in-picture watching. The positive effects of playback for businesses are that some people may prefer to be advertised to quicker or slower depending on how they listen to content and is good especially for those with a poor internet connection as they can still watch the video but with a slightly smaller resolution. The negatives of this however for businesses is that playback features such as speed for example could have to distort the original audio in order to actually make the video slower or faster and the resolutions may not be available for certain videos depending on the recording equipment that the business uses. Here is what the playback menu looks like:



TikTok:

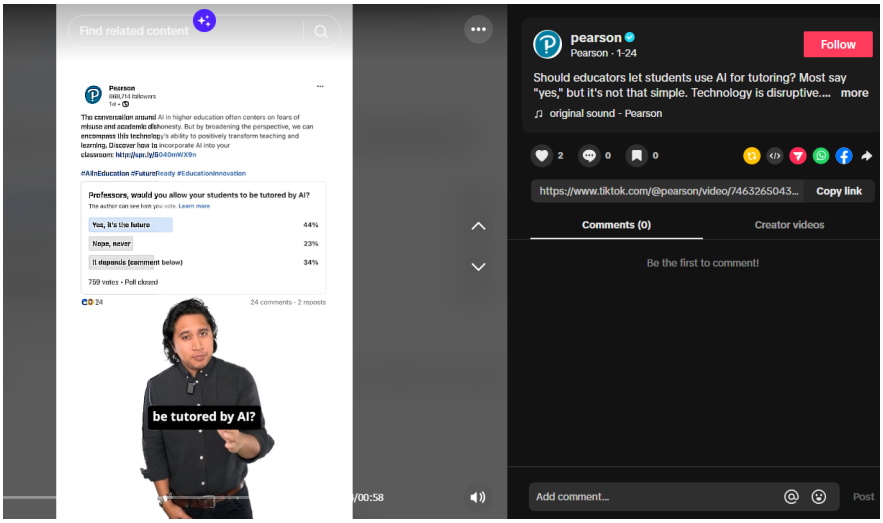
[redacted] [redacted]

TikTok is a social media platform which allows users to create an account and post short-form content ranging between 3 seconds to 10 minutes in length, although recently this has been extended up to 60 minutes in length. It also allows users to communicate with friends, family and friends people may know in the digital world, which in this case makes TikTok a personal use social media platform. Businesses can use this to their advantage because people are more likely to share their content much more compared to a business use social media platform.

Features:

Short-Form Videos

TikTok allows users to create and share videos ranging between 3 seconds to 60 minutes in length, however on the Camera function of the application only allows for up to 10 minutes recording time. This allows businesses to easily promote content in short concise videos which tend to perform better with different audiences who may not want to watch an extremely long video. Users can also record using the camera function to create videos or can import a pre-recorded video to be uploaded to the site. The positive effects of this are that businesses can easily promote content in short concise videos over a duration of time as not everyone wants to watch a 60 minute video about a product and it also allows businesses to record their own videos and from there post them. The negative effects of this are that cyber criminals could pretend to be businesses and post content that the business doesn’t approve of and from there encourage users to install malware via a separate link to an unknown website or commit data pharming on users by collecting their information. Here is an example of a short-form video by Pearson Edexcel on TikTok:



Comments

TikTok features a comment section in the posts that content creators make so that the audience and the content creator can engage with each other via text comments, or the original creator can respond with video messages while embedding them in the original video for context. The positive effect of this is that businesses are easily able to deal with customers complaints and enquires much quicker alongside collecting analytics and feedback through these comments. The negative effect of this is that businesses have to regularly monitor their comments for when people post enquires or complaints because if the business does not respond they may gain a bad reputation and they must also make sure that cyber criminals cannot make messages tricking users to install malware or go to a website where they fill in all their data and from there become a victim of data pharming. This can be seen as above in the previous example by Pearson Edexcel.

[redacted] [redacted]

TikTok LIVE

TikTok has a feature called TikTok LIVE which a live-streaming function that allows users to broadcast live to their followers, although there is a certain criteria that has to be met so that users can go live (1000 followers, 18 years of age or older) and from here followers can send virtual gifts which give monetization to the user alongside allowing for exclusive use of filters and effects. TikTok LIVE is also great for interacting with an audience as it allows 100 users to request at any time to join live as a guest on the user's livestream. The positive effects of TikTok LIVE for businesses is that businesses can easily promote physical products using LIVE, they can receive monetization by followers who send virtual gifts worth money to them and they can also interact with a wider community as up to 100 people can request to go LIVE at any time as a guest. The negative effects of TikTok LIVE however are that business must monitor the guests that are joining at all times as well as the comments section as people can easily leave negative comments in the comment section or display inappropriate behaviour while up live as a guest and this may give the business a bad reputation if they do not deal with this. As well, if the business does not meet the requirements said above to be able to go LIVE, the business will not be able to livestream until they meet both criteria.

Search and Discover

TikTok has a feature called Discover which allows users to discover topics, hashtags and creators that the user may have not known about and from there find out the latest trends that are occurring in the world. As well as this, TikTok also features a search bar which allows users to search for specific content, while also giving suggestions in the search bar based on previous activity that the user has done recently on the platform. The positive effect of Search and Discover for businesses is that people are more likely to be recommended the business's content if they have viewed any of their content recently as Search uses suggestions based on previous searches and activity, and Discover can allow users to easily discover businesses which are becoming popular and which have a big amount of followers. The negative effect of Search and Discover however is that not everyone wants to be promoted suggestion in their search bar for a business that they may have scrolled off due to not being interested and also in Discover small businesses are unlikely to get as much recognition compared to big multi-national companies.

Text Posts

TikTok features Text Posts which allows users to share text-only updates about things they want to discuss about, with the ability to add customisable backgrounds, music, stickers and hashtags which allows users to post words than just videos or images. The positive effect of Text Posts is that businesses have more choice in what they wish to post if they do not want to post videos or images and allow businesses to share updates with a wider community about topics that they want to discuss about. The negative effects of Text Posts are however that users may not want to read text posts and so therefore will scroll past them ignoring the message or discussion that the business was trying to have with its followers and that TikTok is mainly a photo and video discussion based social media platform so Text Posts are unlikely to become as popular as most other types of content that can be posted.

TikTok Stories

TikTok has a feature called TikTok Stories which allows users to share photos or videos that are up to 15 seconds in length which will then vanish after 24 hours, similar to Instagram Stories. TikTok Stories also allows users to apply effects and editing to their posts before they post the content publicly to the wide audience that they may have. The positive effects of TikTok Stories are that businesses are able to post content for a short period of time e.g. discounts which could then be set to disappear after 24 hours making the idea great for promotions. However, the negative effects of TikTok Stories are that anyone can pretend to be the business and post about promotions that do not actually exist, and the business would not be able to act upon this directly.

Multi-Device Support

TikTok features Multi-Device Support which allows users to connect up to four devices to their TikTok account which allows users to access their account even if they cannot on another device. TikTok unlike Instagram also allows desktop and web users to post videos, images and text posts which in turn always gives users a second option if they cannot access their mobile device. The benefits of Multi-Device Support for businesses are that they can easily access their account on up to four different devices and can post even if they don't have access to their main device. The negatives of Multi-Device Support is that cyber criminals who get their hands on one of the businesses devices could easily take over the account pretending to be the business and promote stuff that the business does not endorse such as malware and also data pharming via a post of an external web address so the business must be aware to keep their personal devices safe at all times.

[redacted] [redacted]

WhatsApp

WhatsApp is a social media platform that allows its users to communicate with friends and family alongside businesses who may be far away from the user, alongside allowing users to share photos and videos and private message each other. WhatsApp is owned by Meta, just like Facebook and Instagram, and has been since 2014.

Features:

Text Messaging

WhatsApp allows users to send and receive text messages over an internet connection, which offers a free alternative to regular SMS messaging which tends to cost a lot of money to send messages. Users can text each other one-to-one or with up to 1,024 people in a group chat or community. The positive effects of this for businesses is that they can interact more easily with customers as not everyone can afford to send regular SMS messages and businesses can also create group chats from which lots of different people who have enquires or complaints about a product can be dealt with by the business providing customer service to them. The negative effects of text messaging for businesses however are that many customers don't want to read long text messages as they may prefer visual customer service compared to texting especially if products are being promoted, as well as the fact that you do not know who is behind the account and so therefore the business could be a cyber-criminal trying to either commit a scam or commit data pharming.

Voice and Video Calling

WhatsApp features Voice and Video Calling which allows users to make free video and voice calls using Wi-Fi or mobile data with up to 32 people in the call for both voice and video. The positive effects of this for businesses is that businesses can easily promote their physical products using Video Calling to an audience alongside showing how products function. The negative effects of Voice and Video Calling however is that people don't know if the business is legitimate or not because they don't know who is running the account calling them, some people do not want to be called if they are working in an office job or are at school/college, time zones are also different across the world so businesses could accidentally call someone when it is the middle of the night for them and also Video Calls on WhatsApp are known to be quite laggy if you have a poor internet connection or camera.

WhatsApp Status

WhatsApp features WhatsApp Status which is a feature that allows users to post temporary updates in the form of videos, photos and text that are displayed for 24 hours before disappearing. It is very similar to TikTok Stories and Instagram Stories in terms of its features. The positive effects of WhatsApp Status are that businesses are able to post content for a short period of time e.g. discounts which could then be set to disappear after 24 hours making the idea great for promotions. However, the negative effects of WhatsApp Status are that anyone can pretend to be the business and post about promotions that do not actually exist, and the business would not be able to act upon this directly.

Cross-Platform Support

WhatsApp allows users to access their computers to their account from which they can send messages on desktop or even video or voice call using desktop. Users can access WhatsApp on other devices by using a QR code which is generated by the mobile app. The positive effects of Cross-Platform Support for businesses are that they can easily access their account and can post or video/voice call even if they don't have access to their main device. The negatives of Cross-Platform Support is that cyber criminals who get their hands on one of the businesses devices could easily take over the account pretending to be the business and promote stuff that the business

does not endorse such as malware and also data pharming via a post of an external web address so the business must be aware to keep their personal devices safe at all times.

Media Sharing

WhatsApp allows its users to share files with each other in messages such as photos, videos, documents (including PDFs) as well as voice messages. Media can also be sent in its original quality unlike traditional SMS messaging which usually requires heavy compression of files. The positive effect of Media Sharing for businesses is that businesses can easily promote content to a vast amount of users quickly as well as easily being able to promote their products and services to potential interested customers. The negative effect of Media Sharing for businesses is however that cyber criminals could pretend to be a business and share files that contain malware within them such as viruses or worms which can damage the customer's computer alongside promoting links to external websites which could be used for data pharming.

Disappearing Messages

WhatsApp features an option called Disappearing Messages which allows users to set their messages to disappear after 24 hours, 7 days or 90 days. The positive effects of Disappearing Messages are that businesses are able to post messages for a short period of time e.g. discounts which could then be set to disappear after 24 hours making the idea great for promotions. However, the negative effects of Disappearing Messaging are that anyone can pretend to be the business and post about promotions that do not actually exist, and the business would not be able to act upon this directly as if the time had gone past the message would disappear like nothing happened.

Voice Messages

WhatsApp allows users to record voice messages and from there allows users to choose the playback speed (0.5x, 1x, 1.5x or 2x). The positive effects of Voice Messages for businesses are that some people may prefer to be advertised to quicker or slower depending on how they listen to content and is good especially for those with a poor internet connection as they can still listen to the voice message. The negatives of this however for businesses is that playback features such as speed for example could have to distort the original audio in order to actually make the voice message slower or faster.

Typical target audience

Facebook

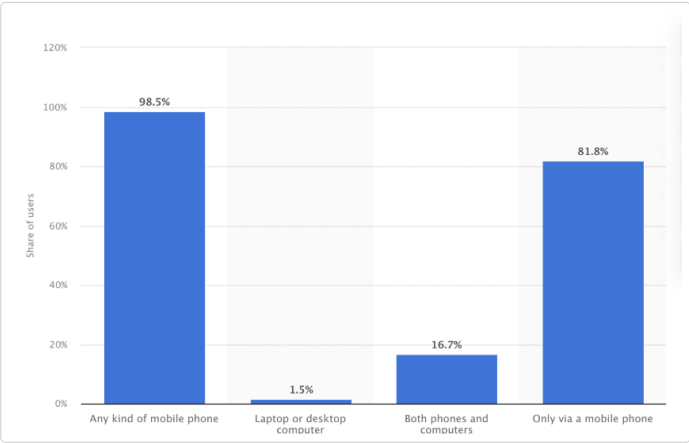
Facebook remains the most used social media platform in 2024 with India being the country with the most Facebook users across the world with 378.05 million users. Meta's revenue reached 134 billion USD in 2024, showing just how profitable Facebook really is.

Country	Users (in millions)
India	378.05
United States	193.8
Indonesia	119.05
Brazil	112.55
Mexico	92.7

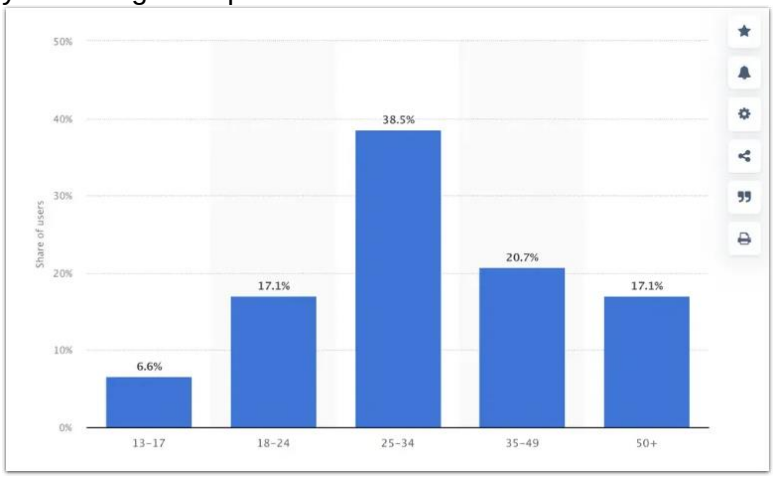
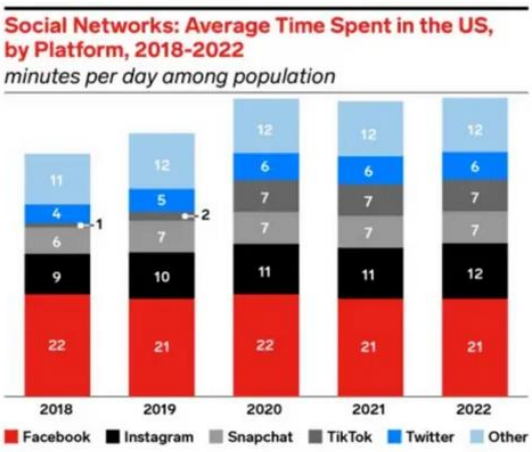
Facebook has 3.06 billion monthly active users, beating YouTube and WhatsApp by over 1 billion users. Facebook has 408 monthly million users in Europe, with 19% of users being teens and 69% of users being millennials.

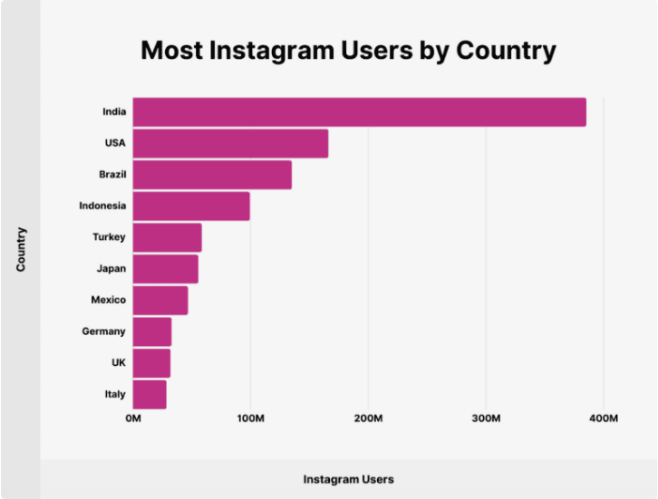
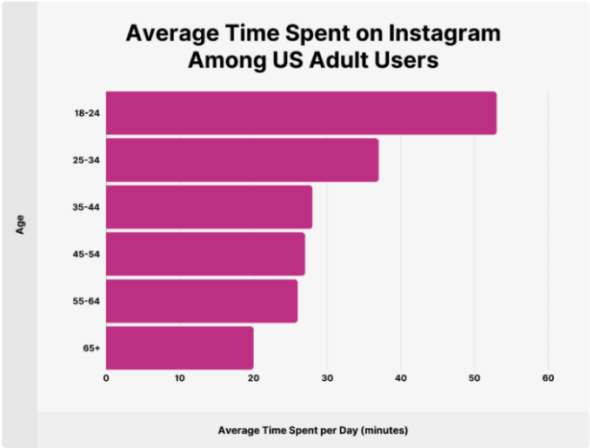
15% of users shop on Facebook while 86% of global marketers use Facebook for their strategies and 60% of shoppers use Facebook to get customer service alongside 69% of marketers use the platform for customer service.

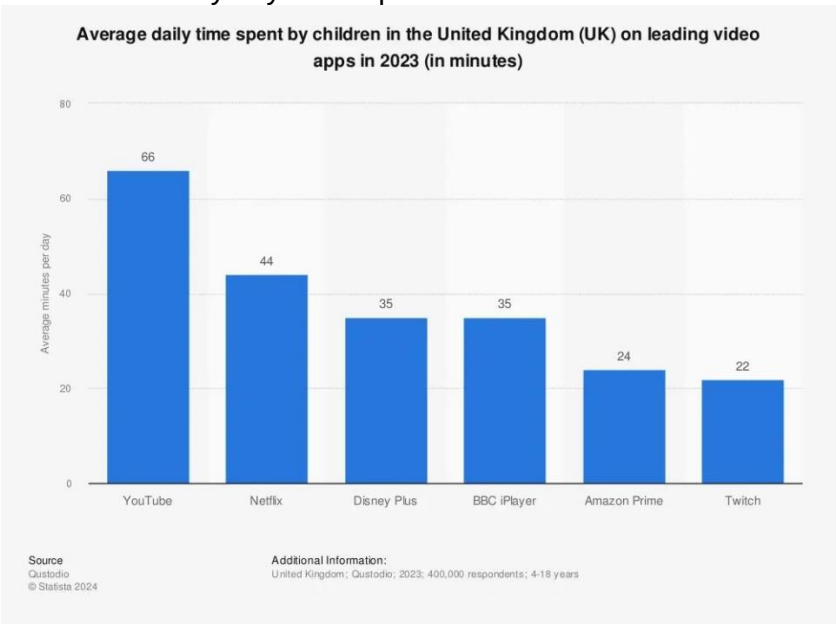
98.5% of Facebook users access the platform from mobile devices while, only 1.5% of Facebook users only use a computer to access Facebook.

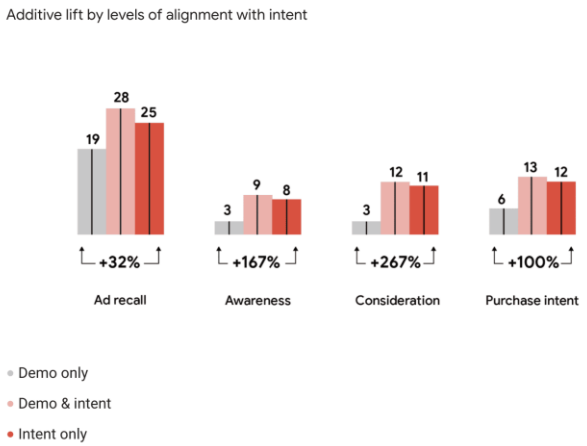
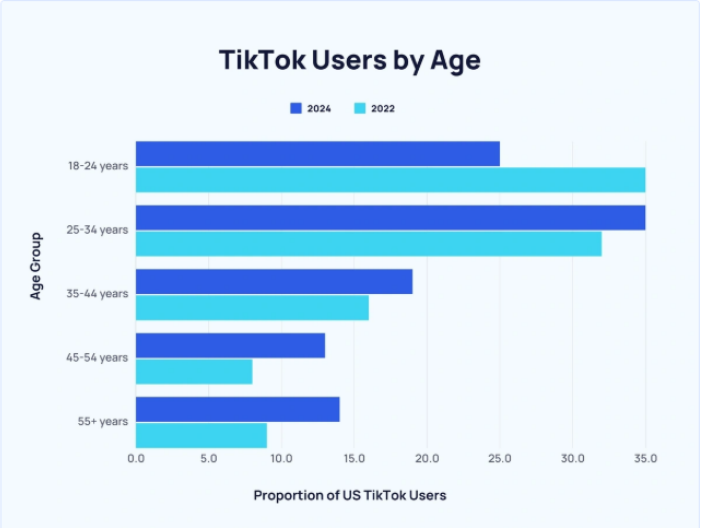


[redacted] [redacted]

	Facebook users access the platform at least 8 times daily and people spend around 17 hours and 20 minutes a month of Facebook with 72.4% of users use the platform to connect with loved ones and 58.2% use the platform to stay updated with the latest news. Facebook has 408 monthly million users in Europe, with 19% of users being teens and 69% of users being millennials. Facebook is home to 200 million small businesses and from this 89% of customers are more likely to purchase products according to a recent study. Reference: https://meetanshi.com/blog/facebook-statistics/#:~:text=On%20average%2C%20users%20access%20Facebook,every%20month%20use%20Facebook%20Groups.
Twitter	X has a total of 206 million daily active users with 17.4% of users on X being between ages 18 and 24 and 38.5% of users on X between ages 25 and 34. This means that 55.9% of X users are less than 40 years of age compared to Facebook.  66.72% of users are male on X compared to 23.28% of females on X. X users alone in the US spend 34.1 minutes a day on the platform. An average user on X usually spends 3.39 minutes on X. 42% of users have a college degree.  X is the 9th most visited website across the globe.

	391 million accounts on X don't even have a single follower. 500 million tweets sent per day on X by March 2025. Twitter has 396.5 million users globally. People see X advertisements for 26% longer. Advertisements are extremely cheap on X compared to any other social media platform with the average price being $6.46. References: https://www.incrementors.com/blog/facts-about-twitter/ and https://khoros.com/resources/social-media-demographics-guide
Instagram	Instagram's has a total of 2 billion monthly active users and is rated the 3rd most popular social network across the globe. Instagram is most popular in India where 385.35 million users use the platform and people spend roughly 33.9 minutes daily on Instagram.   78% of people who use Instagram are between the ages of 18 and 29 and 55% of people educated at more than a college level use the

	app. 54% of users that earn more than $100,000 use the app and 49.94% of users have between 1,000 to 10,000 followers. 90% of Instagram users follow a business and 2 out of 3 people say Instagram allows interaction with brands while 83% of users say they discover new products and services through Instagram. References: https://khoros.com/resources/social-media-demographics-guide and https://backlinko.com/instagram-users
YouTube	YouTube has 2.491 billion monthly active users and has 122 million daily active users with more than one-third of users being between the ages of 18-44. It is rated the 2nd most popular social media network across the globe, with India being the country with the most users at 476 million users. YouTube's userbase is male which make up 54.3% of the platform, while 46.7% are female. Children between the ages of 4 to 18 in the UK spend approximately 66 minutes every day on the platform.  There are 27.9 million users who pay for YouTube Premium and enjoy ad-free videos. As of June 2022, more than 500 hours of videos were uploaded every minute, with more than 40.9% of watch time happening on mobile devices. YouTube Shorts has more than 1.5 billion monthly active users. 70% of users have made a purchase after seeing a brand being promoted on YouTube.

	 Ads targeted using intent have a 100% higher lift in purchase interest, and pre-roll advertisements which are skippable are said to be the most effective. The platform is used by 54% of marketers and the ideal length for a YouTube video is between 7 to 15 minutes in length. References: https://thesocialshepherd.com/blog/youtube-statistics/ and https://khoros.com/resources/social-media-demographics-guide/
TikTok	TikTok has 1.218 billion monthly active users, and the platform has 45.1 million daily active users with more than one-third of users, 37.3%, between the ages of 18 and 24 on TikTok.  50.8% of users on TikTok are male, compared to 49.2% of females on TikTok. On average, a user spends 8 minutes and 18 seconds on the platform daily and TikTok has a bounce rate of 55.46%.

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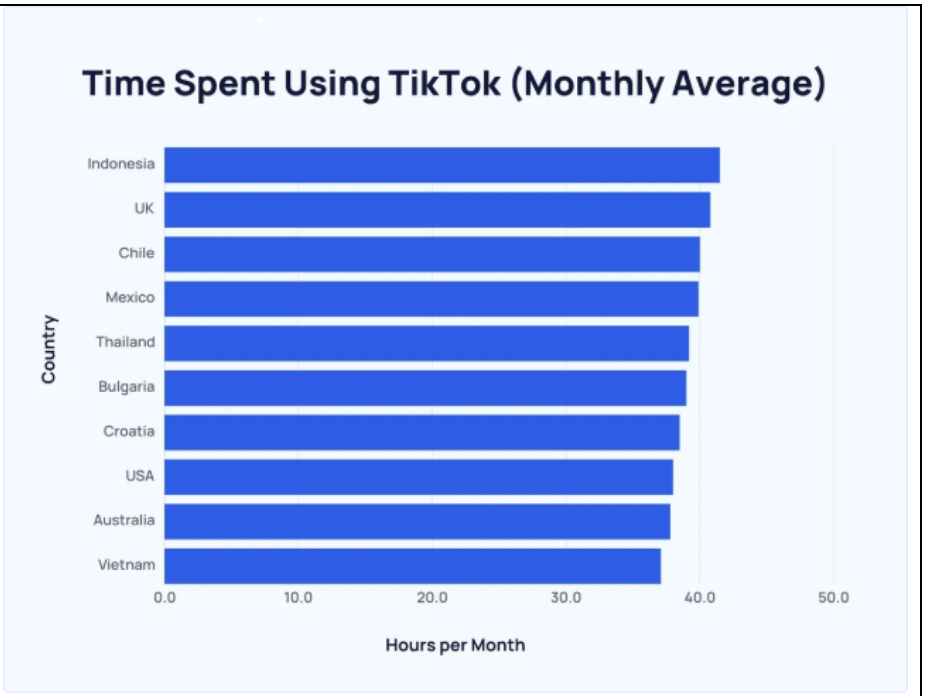

Consumer spending on TikTok has surpassed $2.5 billion globally and 58.2% of users said the platform was good for shopping inspiration while 49% of users say the platform helped make purchasing decisions and 55% of TikTok users made a purchase after seeing a brand or product on the platform.
References : https://khoros.com/resources/social-media-demographics-guide and https://explodingtopics.com/blog/tiktok-demographics
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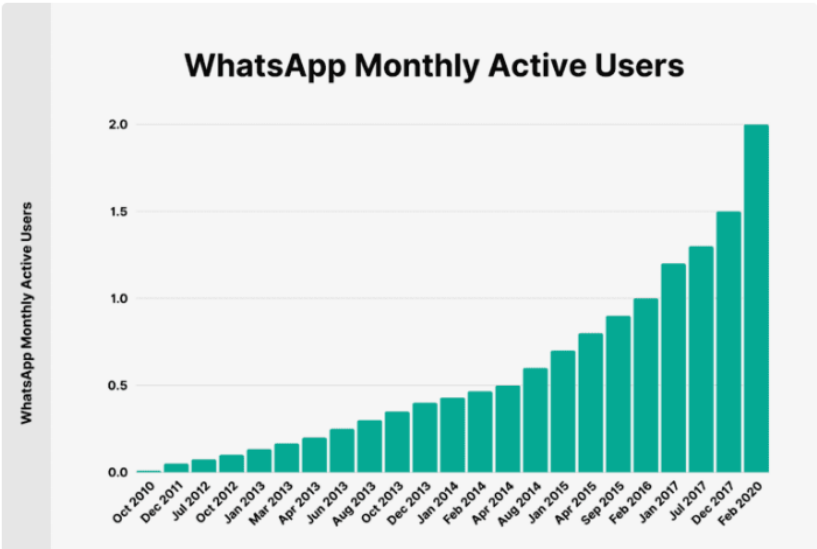
<tr>
<td>WhatsApp</td>
<td>
WhatsApp has over 2 billion monthly active users worldwide and has 100 million monthly active users in the US. It is ranked as the most used mobile messenger app in the world. More than 596.6 million messages and voice messages are sent each day on WhatsApp.


WhatsApp users worldwide on the Android app spent 16 hours 32 minutes per month (around 33.1 minutes per day) on the app between 1 March and 31 May 2024. Gen Z and Millennials account
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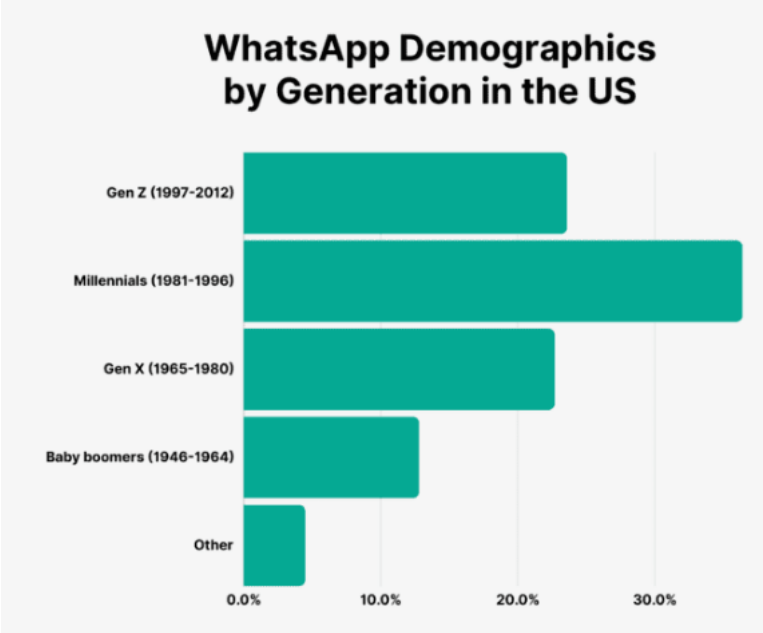
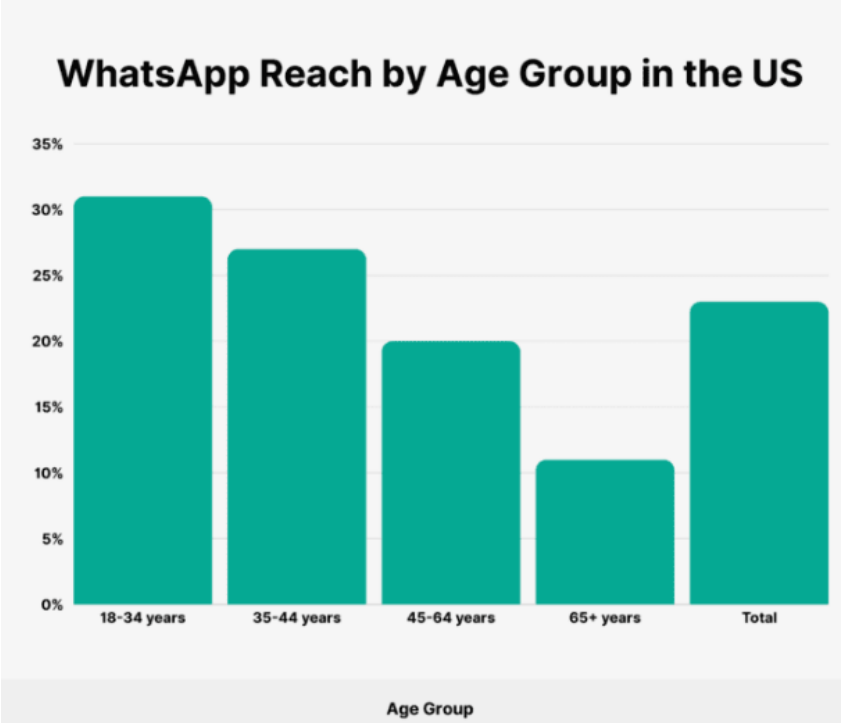
for over half (60%) of WhatsApp monthly active user base in the US.



WhatsApp is most popular among Americans aged between 18-34, with 31% of them having a WhatsApp account as of May 2022.



WhatsApp's worldwide user base consisted of 47.7% female users while 52.2% were male. WhatsApp has a dedicated app for managing business profiles and staying in touch with customers. WhatsApp Business reached 200 million monthly active users in June 2023, a 4x increase from 50 million reported in July 2020.

Reference: https://backlinko.com/whatsapp-users

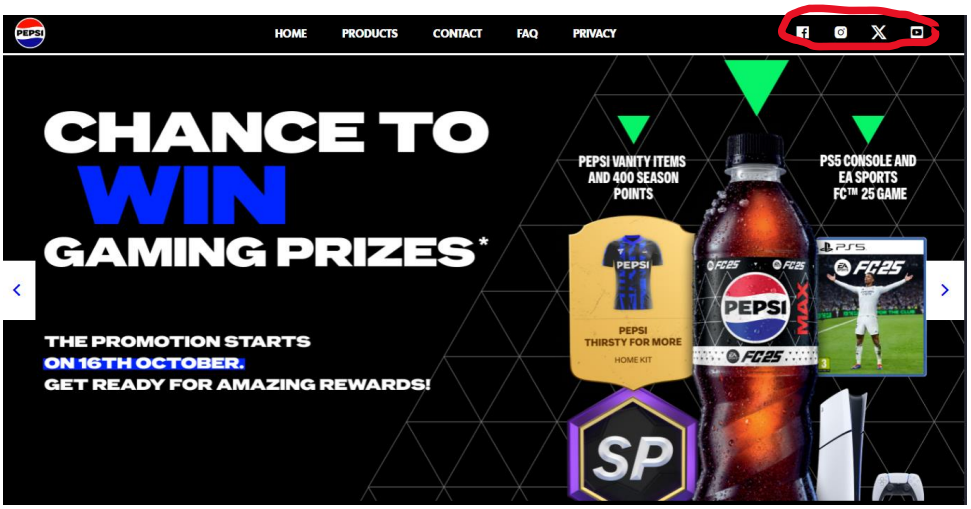
How Businesses Use Social Media

In this section, I will be discussing how businesses use social media to post content, how they communicate with customers as well as how they develop their social media audience.

How businesses set-up their social media website and post content

The business I will be researching is Pepsi which is a soft drinks company based various parts of the world as a multi-national company. Their main social media website is based at https://www.pepsi.co.uk/ for the United Kingdom.

Pepsi describes themselves as a soft drinks company that want people to join their "Pepsi Pioneers" which is the name of their sponsorships, alongside telling people to be bold and be themselves. They regularly talk about the soft drink flavours that they have made and how the public reacts very positively towards these specific flavours, alongside talking about new releases of products.



The target market that Pepsi targets are Gen Z and people between the ages of 15 to 45 both of which are male and female in gender. Pepsi's target audience also consists of working-class, middle-class and upper-class individuals including students, employees and professionals. According to my reference, 78% of Pepsi drinkers buy Pepsi at a grocery store, and 74% buy Pepsi at big box stores, while 62% purchase the beverage at convenience stores and 44% at vending machines.
Reference:https://www.start.io/blog/pepsi-target-market-analysis-audience-segmentation-marketing-strategy/

[redacted] [redacted]

Pepsi uses a number of social media sites that appeal to their audience, with the main sites being Facebook and Instagram, however they do use some other social media sites such as X and YouTube to promote their products and services to a wider audience of their target market to ensure they get as many sales as possible without spending lots of money and getting next to no profit in return. For Facebook, according to my references, 89% of Facebook users are more likely to buy products that they see on Facebook which makes it more likely that users will buy Pepsi products in the future. For Instagram, according to my references, 83% of users use Instagram to discover new products which makes it more likely people who have never tried Pepsi will want to try it in the future.

Other social media sites such as X and YouTube might also appeal to their audience because on X users see advertisements for 26% longer and advertisements are cheaper on X compared to any other platform. Meanwhile, YouTube is great for physical and practical products and therefore could work well for Pepsi.

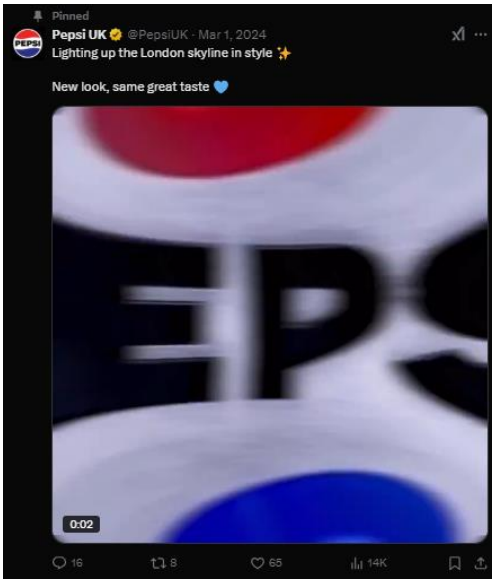
Facebook:

On Facebook, Pepsi is creating an image by creating posts about their products with physical images of the products which interests users while they are searching through their account. They also make use of Facebook Reels to promote their physical products as it allows businesses to create short-form content up to 90 seconds long which easily promote content and gets more viewers compared to just text and images, as well as being easily shareable and viewable using Stories. Alongside this, their account has a Meta Verified badge which proves to their target audience that it is them who are making these posts and Facebook Reels, alongside being a notable brand.

[redacted] [redacted]

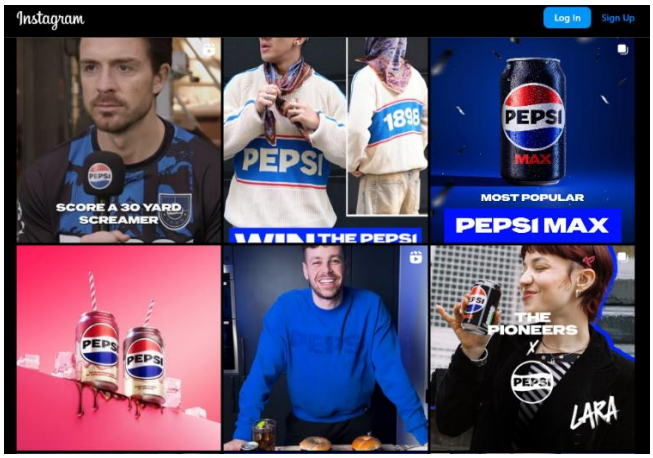
Twitter/X:

Meanwhile, on X, Pepsi makes use of pinned tweets containing videos and text which allows them to easily grab the attention of users who are searching through their account. They use Twitter Blue because they are a verified business account which allows them to post up to 4000 words in one Tweet, although their tweets are usually not near 280 words which is what attracts users as Twitter's tweets are about getting to the point of what the product is for businesses.



Instagram:

On Instagram, Pepsi makes use of both regular image posts to easily grab the attention of users and Instagram Reels to promote their content which allows them to promote their content in short-form videos and they are often viewed more often than long-form videos in comparison, as well as being easily promotable. As well as this, the number of views is available to see on Instagram Reels, showing that Pepsi usually gets from around 2000 viewers on just one Instagram Reel to around 74,600 people.



YouTube:

On YouTube, Pepsi makes use of uploading videos and YouTube Shorts to promote their content alongside sponsorships with influencers on the platform, which often draws a lot of people into viewing their page and their products. However, the risks of this are that fake accounts also exist on YouTube which claim to be the real accounts of the same company and so people fall victim to scams. As Pepsi is a physical product as well, it is perfect for Pepsi to able to advertise the product to its target audience. Pepsi also regularly uses Google Ads through YouTube to enrol advertisements they want onto YouTube for people to watch during an ad break. This is even better as it can directly show viewers how the product functions as a soft drink and where they can find the product.

Now I will discuss three different types of posts that Pepsi has made using these different social media platforms and why they may have promoted their products or services:

Post 1:

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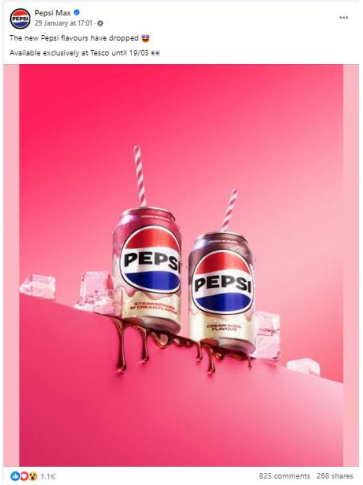


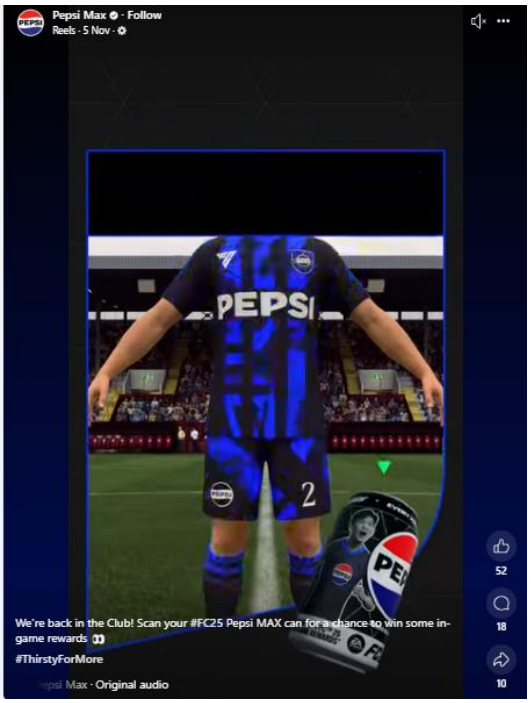
Pepsi may have decided to post using images on Facebook to easily hook users viewing their profile straight onto their new products that they were releasing, alongside already existing customers of Pepsi who may or may not have known that they had release any new products and therefore may want to try it out. This therefore allows users to easily understand what is being promoted by the company and from there people may share the content to friends and family they know who like Pepsi and who may be interested in these new products.

Post 2:

Pepsi may have chosen to use videos using YouTube because the platform is great for physical products and so therefore Pepsi is able to describe what the product is and promote their content while also gaining influencer sponsorships as it allows the business to reach a wider audience. YouTube is also great for long-form content which therefore allows corporations like Pepsi to go into great details about what their

product is about and since YouTube's audience mainly watches long-form content this would the perfect platform to use for the specs of a product.

Post 3:



Pepsi may have chosen Facebook Reels because short-form video content easily allows business to promote their content in videos up to 90 seconds long. They also

tend to attract more viewers, likes, shares and comments compared to regular posts, images and videos. Pepsi using Facebook Reels can also easily promote content in short concise videos which tend to perform better with different audiences who may not want to watch an extremely long video or read an extremely long post and Facebook Reels can also be easily promoted via the use of Facebook Stories, which is another feature of the platform.

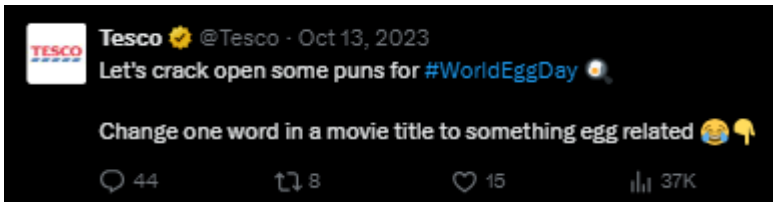
Different types of posts used to engage a target audience:

I will be focusing on Tesco which is a grocery store in the United Kingdom which sells most different types of foods alongside things essential to everyday life. Tesco tends to use many different methods to find out statistics regarding their customers and I will be going over three different examples from which Tesco has used social media to plot demographics about their customers.

Post 1:

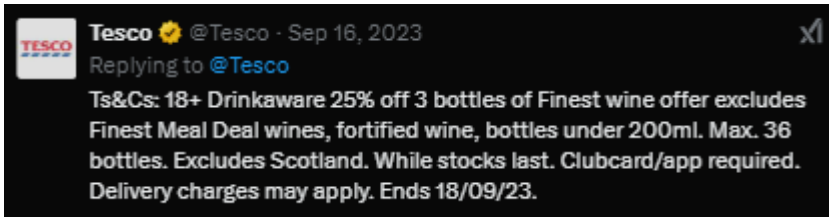
Tesco often tends to use polls to find out statistics regarding their audience and therefore plot demographics from these polls to create a very wide audience based on the most popular response given here, as seen where people rated on this Tesco post. This allows Tesco to from here determine what would be the best time to have stock of products available, alongside allowing Tesco to find out the opinions of their customers as each individual opinion of shoppers matter heavily to their business. They could implement these polls via the use of X, Facebook, YouTube and in general most social media platforms which have this functionality.

Post 2:



Tesco often tends to use humour in their posts to try and relate to their target audience and customers especially towards a younger Gen Z audience which are much less serious compared to other generations of audience depending on their age and so therefore Tesco as shown here is creating a wider audience as more people are likely to view their page. Tesco tends to usually implement these humorous posts on X, Facebook and YouTube as these social media platforms tend to have a lot of users below the age of 45.

Post 3:



Tesco often promote special offers and discounts using many social media platforms to be able to reach out to customers of the brand and new customers alongside their target audience who are interested in buying products that the brand sells and often discount products to make people interested in specific products. This therefore

increases the number of sales that Tesco makes on this particular product, as can be seen here where there is a discount they posted on X for 3 bottles of Finest wine at 25% off.

Sponsored Advertisements

Businesses also tend to make use of sponsored advertisements which often used on many social media platforms to interest users in their products and services while users may be searching through their dashboards. These are usually paid for except in the odd circumstance when they are sponsored for free. The benefits of them to businesses are that businesses can easily promote new products and services using this form of content while perhaps interesting new customers and getting customers who have already bought stuff from them, meanwhile the risks of this is that fraud is often committed using these as anyone can promote products pretending to be a business and the company can't directly act on it.

For the demographics, businesses have a specific target audience that they set based on who they think will want to buy their products. They use algorithms on the social media websites based on the user's information they inputted to recommend them content they may like e.g. Pepsi if they are food influencers for 15 to 45-year-olds. Depending if people scroll on or not as well on sites also affects what the algorithm will recommend them.

Use of Cookies and Search History

Advertisers usually pay to find out the information of an individual based on their recent search history to promote similar related products that they may be interested in across multiple different platforms to try and get them to buy the products that they are offering. The only issue with this is that you don't know how much the information is being sold for and if the person consented to having their information sold to these businesses.

How Social Media Sites Are Tailored for Mobile Devices

Social media sites are tailored for mobile devices using better images, cleaner CTAs, reformatted videos and posts to allow businesses to access their posts anywhere and promote their products, as well as to allow consumers to look at these products and therefore being interested in these products.

Reference: https://blog.woobox.com/2018/05/how-to-tailor-your-social-media-content-for-mobile-

users/#:~:text=Little%20tweaks%20on%20your%20social,better%20optimized%20for%20mobile%20viewing

How Businesses Communicate with Customers on Social Media

The business I will be researching is Transport for London, which is a transportation company that operates in the capital city of the United Kingdom which in this case is London. Transport for London regularly communicates with its customers and target audience about updates to their services alongside collecting customer feedback, and this is great for analysis purposes for Transport for London.

Transport for London often uses posts on social media sites like Facebook and X to communicate updates and changes with their services. They often use comments to respond to customer feedback to gather opinions as it is a cheaper way of conducting market research and makes users feel like their feedback is valued.

They often include contact information in the form of a website form/survey to collect information from their customers in terms of feedback or they leave a telephone number or some other way of communication to get in contact with customers.

Transport for London also provides customer service by monitoring their profiles to check for comments from other users who have complaints and from there making posts in the form of comments to respond to customer service issues. They often attach some form of contact information to ensure that customers who have complaints can get in contact with the right department in their business.

[redacted] [redacted]

Why is it important for businesses to respond to customers?

It is important for businesses to respond to comments to ensure that they do not get a bad reputation because customers may think that they don't care about their customers, and they are trying to appeal to their target market while dealing with any issues that existing customers may experience during this.

It is also very important for businesses to consider carefully on how to respond to their customers because a simple "Sorry" cannot fix many issues because many customer service issues require either technical support or a complaint form so therefore a simple apology will not solve the issue that customers are facing. As well as this, saying nothing at all will give them a bad reputation because customers will assume that they don't care about their customers.

Creating a Posting Schedule

It is important that businesses create a posting schedule as it shows an outline of when you plan to post and how often alongside what type of material you will be posting. It also outlines what social media platforms you

will be posting on at a specific date alongside the time that the content will be posted.

If a posting schedule is not created to be posting regularly, e.g. a business only would post once every two weeks, then people may end up forgetting what the business is and what the business is about which therefore would result in a lot of their target audience no longer looking at their content.

Also, the time of which you are posting also heavily matters because due to differing time zones across the world, many people may not to be able to view the content that you post, alongside people going to work or school/college who may not be able to see your content until at least a lot later into the day.

The platforms you also will be posting on matter heavily because if you decide to post only on one platform you may also be targeting a very small amount of your wide audience but if you decide to post on 30 different social medias sure you would be reaching your widened audience but it would be too much work to try and manage 30 separate social media accounts, alongside possibly being very expensive to try and promote your content on there so it’s often recommended to only post on a few social media platforms but not all of them.

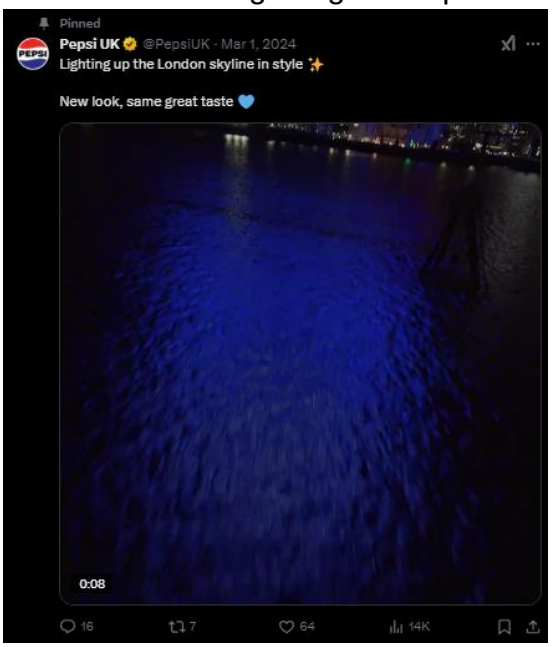
How Businesses Develop their Social Media Audience

[redacted] [redacted]

The business I will be researching Pepsi again. Pepsi is a soft drinks company based various parts of the world as a multi-national company.

Engaging Content

Pepsi often creates posts with videos and text on X to target their older target market as their target audience is people between the ages of 15 to 45. They often make use of pinned tweets which allows them to easily grab the attention of their market who are searching through their account. They use Twitter Blue because they are a verified business account which allows them to post up to 4000 words in one Tweet, although their tweets are usually not near 280 words which is what attracts their market as Twitter's tweets are about getting to the point of what the product is for businesses.



On Instagram, Pepsi makes use of both regular image posts to easily grab the attention of their market and Instagram Reels to promote their content which allows them to promote their content in short-form videos and they are often viewed more often than long-form videos in comparison, as well as being easily promotable. As well as this, the number of views is available to see on Instagram Reels, showing that Pepsi usually gets from around 2000 viewers on just one Instagram Reel to around 74,600 people.

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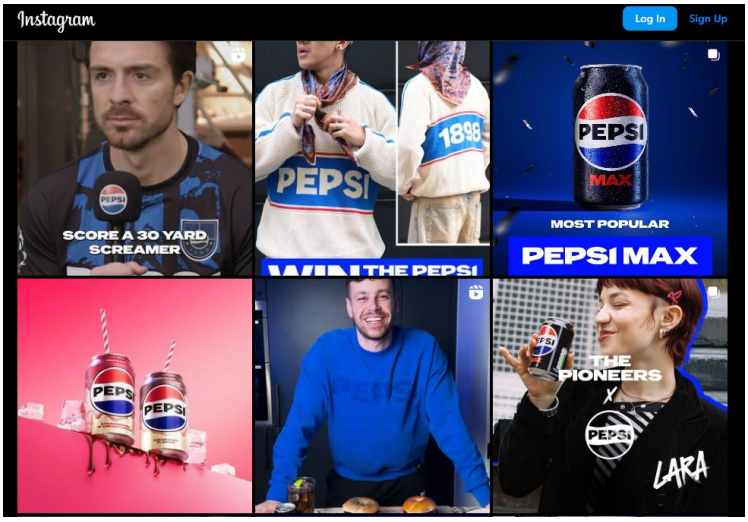
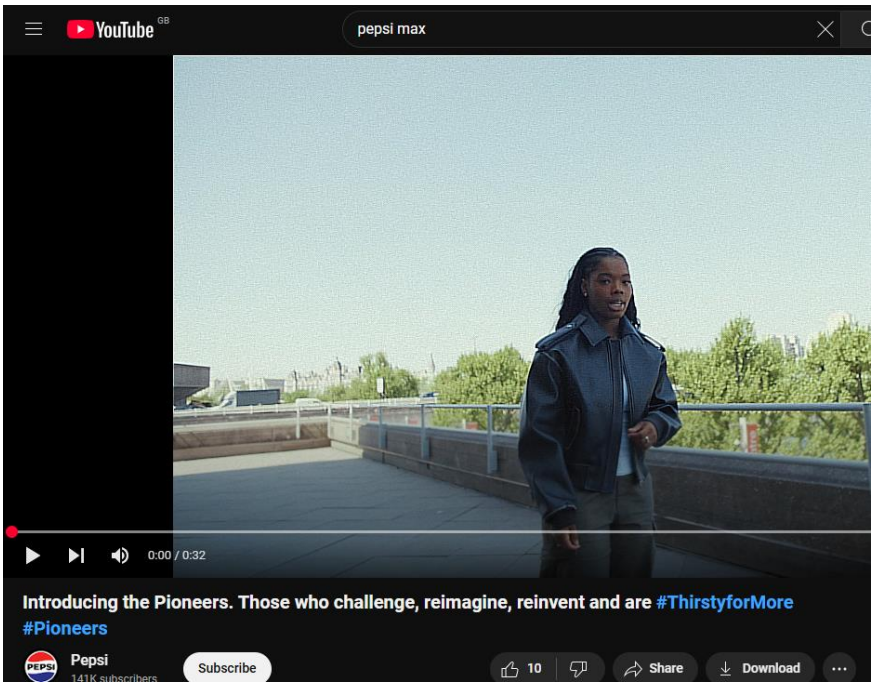


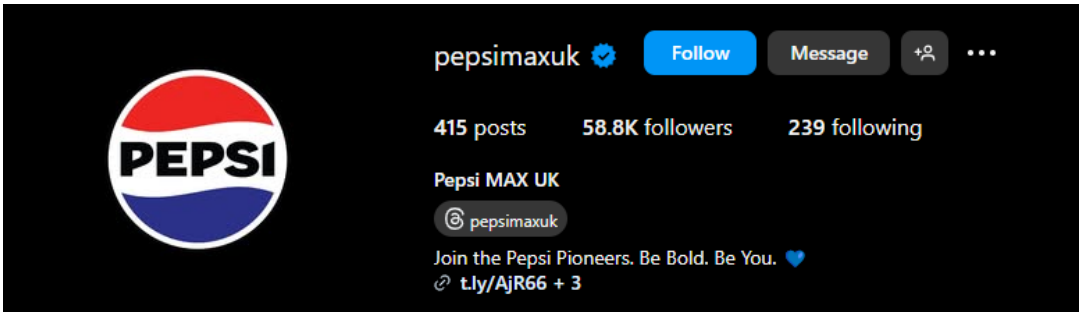
On YouTube, Pepsi makes use of uploading videos and YouTube Shorts to promote their content alongside sponsorships with influencers on the platform, which often draws a lot of their target market into viewing their page and their products. However, the risks of this are that fake accounts also exist on YouTube which claim to be the real accounts of the same company and so people fall victim to scams. As Pepsi is a physical product as well, it is perfect for Pepsi to able to advertise the product to its target audience. Pepsi also regularly uses Google Ads through YouTube to enrol advertisements they want onto YouTube for people to watch during an ad break. This is even better as it can directly show viewers how the product functions as a soft drink and where they can find the product.



Pepsi does not usually tend to use keywords in their posts or Reels but rather they tend to use one word or a one-word sentence for posts in general.

[redacted] [redacted]

On Instagram, Pepsi has a total of 58.8K followers of which most are in the Gen Z generation and between the ages of 15 to 45 of both genders. Their followers also consist of working-class, middle-class and upper-class individuals including students, employees and professionals. This is important because they are using demographics to determine how to promote their content easily across multiple different types of people.



This post on Instagram by Pepsi has 1,162 likes which compared to most other content that Pepsi posts is about the average amount of likes a post gets. Usually, Pepsi gets more likes when they are either promoting new released products they have made or when they are talking about any of their products or promotions in general and how to win them.

Keywords

Businesses use keywords in their posts often to use indirect advertising and to increase the number of users that watch their videos or read their posts and because different audiences are engaged by different things. They also want to widen their demographics by ensuring that people of all different backgrounds can access the product and in turn widen Pepsi's target audience.

[redacted] [redacted]

Search Engine Optimisation (SEO)

Search Engine Optimisation is the process of improving the rankings of websites in unpaid search results. This is important so that if a customer searches for a particular product the company will pay to appear high up on the list so that the customer chooses them for that product. Customers are very unlikely to choose businesses that do not appear on the first page of search results and all businesses therefore want to improve which makes SEO a huge topic which many companies spend a lot of time and effort on.

Lots of Likes, Shares and Comments

Lots of likes, shares and comments allows you to reach your target market more easily as people who like the content are more likely to share it and therefore attract people who may not have heard of Pepsi before or consumers of Pepsi to look at the posts and therefore create a wider audience.

Comments must be monitored regularly to ensure that enquiries by potential customers are answered and so that the business does not get a bad reputation if they do not answer comments as customers could think that the business doesn't care about their opinions or criticism.

Lots of likes and shares can also be a bad thing because different content engages different people hence most of the time you won't get the same number of likes like on another post and shares could also be used to spread the bad reputation of the business therefore destroying their wide audience and reducing it to constant criticism.

Web Traffic Analysis (WTA)

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Businesses often use web traffic analytics to determine how many individual people have visited their site and how they may have got to their site (e.g. advertisement, inputting link into browser and social media pages). It also collects information about what people do on their sites, whether checking out new posts or other social medias that the business owns alongside what their business is about. The effectiveness of posts to use web traffic analytics is usually very successful because businesses try to post engaging and enjoyable content that people of all demographics will enjoy as they want to ensure that a product is available to all. Web Traffic Analysis helps determine how individuals interact with their business and therefore plan what to post next or what social media accounts they may want to develop next.

Why business may develop contacts:

As people are more likely to share posts from a business, people who may not have heard of the business before or consumers of a business would look at the posts and this would therefore create a wider audience and some of these users may be very famous influencers or businesses which could be great for promotions or partnerships across many different brands.

Why business may want to develop contacts:

It allows different users across different platforms which are part of their target market to become part of a wide audience whereby all the social media sites that the business use are all linked by the main business which establishes a common link between all the different platforms and therefore they could from there use web traffic analytics to collect information about what people do on their sites, whether checking out new posts or other social medias that the business owns alongside what their business is actually about.

Risks and Issues with Business Use of Social Media

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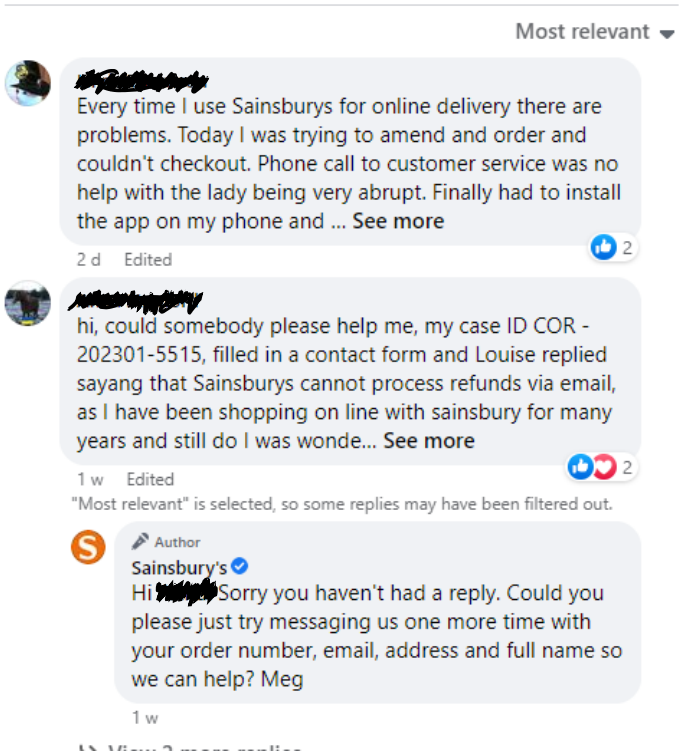
Negative Comments

Negative comments in the form of complaints can be damaging to a business's reputation as it makes people feel that products may not to be the standard required or if the company simply doesn't respond that may make customers feel like they do not care about their customer's opinions and feedback about products. To mitigate this risk, negative comments need to be dealt with quickly dealt with by providing customer service to these customers or they could face a risk of bad reputation and therefore make them lose customers.



Importance of Time

Time is needed to achieve results and therefore many people running small businesses may not have enough time. If the business doesn't post regularly or interact with their customers by responding to their comments, then followers of the business will lose interest, and people may forget about them therefore causing sales to end up suffering.

Posts that accidentally cause upset

Businesses must understand that not all posts they make are appropriate and that there are a wide range of opinions and beliefs across different the public. Sometimes

content that businesses post they think that is appropriate is deemed inappropriate by others. One example of a post that caused upset was the 2013 Boston Marathon in which a terrorist event happened during the race. Two homemade bombs were detonated and three people died. Dozens of others suffered serious injuries, and sixteen victims lost their limbs due to this bomb going off. Adidas seemed to have forgotten about how people had died and lost their limbs because shortly afterwards they sent an insensitive and offensive email to the runners after the event with the subject being “Congrats, you survived the Boston Marathon” which disrespects the event that occurred the same day. To prevent this from happening, Adidas for example could have said “We heard about the events that happened at the Boston Marathon, and we are truly sorry to hear people had passed away and people had suffered serious and life-changing injures.”

Dangers of virus infections

Cyber criminals could use a business pretending to be the business and post something encouraging users to visit a website by clicking on a link and from there they would therefore download malware also known as malicious software which causes damage to their computer. To mitigate this, businesses must ensure that they spot any posts that do not belong to the business alongside monitoring their comments and posts to ensure people cannot fall for the trick of visiting the site.

Dangers of blackmail and ransom

The dangers of blackmail/ransom are that cyber criminals could cause a Denial-of-Service attack (DoS) on a company’s website and therefore prevent legitimate users from accessing the website and demand money from the business for them to stop attacking the website. They could also demand money to get them to stop hacking their accounts and from customers in the form of ransomware software to demand money from them to remove their software and not destroy their files. This could be mitigated by ensuring that the server is able to hand multiple requests at once or by preventing users with a similar IP address doing several requests at the same time, alongside secure passwords and making customers aware about not visiting links not by the business.

Dangers of data leaks

Members of staff working for the business may inadvertently give away private company information or accidentally share customer information in response to queries or complaints in their comments. If a company experiences a data breach,

they need to report it to the data protection authorities within 72 hours or face intense fines as they would be breaking the Data Protection Act of 2018 (GDPR). To mitigate this, staff must be therefore trained on what they can and cannot do while using social media, encrypt all data and have security policies.

Conclusion

There are overall many advantages and disadvantages to using social media when it comes to promoting things for a business. I will now be summarising the key takeaways from what wrote. The main advantages for using social media for businesses is that businesses are easily able to promote content much easier to their customers, alongside providing customer service to deal with queries and complaints that customers may have and interacting with a wider target market through the use of comments and shares to interest more people in viewing their content. However, there are also many risks while using social media. The main risks of using social media for businesses is that they are very prone to getting a bad reputation if they do not help out their customers as they may feel like they do not have a voice and a simple “Sorry” cannot fix issues that customers may be facing, the importance of timing when creating posts and a posting schedule is also important as if a business doesn’t regularly post they could be forgotten by their audience. Virus infections are also a huge risk for businesses as businesses must ensure that they spot any posts that do not belong to the business alongside monitoring their comments and posts to ensure people cannot fall for the trick of installing malware and from there damaging their computer, alongside blackmail as cyber criminals could prevent legitimate users from accessing the website using a Denial-of-Service attack and demand money from the business for them to stop attacking the website. Alongside this, another huge risk is data theft as if the business fails to properly report data leaks to the data protection authorities within 72 hours, they could face intense fines as they would be breaking the Data Protection Act of 2018 (GDPR). Overall, the use of social media for small businesses truly depends on whether they have enough money, time, resources and customers in order to be able to promote their content to a wide audience.

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